

**Dignity, Property, and Security: The Valuation of  
Venal Offices in the Reign of Louis XIV, according to  
Colbert's *Enquête* of 1665**



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## **Abstract**

The *Grand Siècle* witnessed a remarkable expansion of the venal office system, in which the French crown conferred upon individuals the right to sell, exchange, and transmit their offices to heirs. Although historians have thoroughly studied this topic, current scholarship lacks large-scale quantitative analysis and the use of modern financial models. This thesis aims to examine the determinants of office prices and assess to what extent venal offices behaved like modern financial assets with economically rational prices. The area of study is France during the reign of Louis XIV, and the main primary source is Colbert's systematic survey of office prices in 1665. This thesis also makes use of the findings of a recent quantitative study by Bonhoure, Musy, and Tallec (2024) and analyses the well-established scholarship on venal offices by Guy Rowlands, William Doyle, Mark Potter, Roland Mousnier, Christophe Blanquie, Daniel Dessert, among others; this is essential to understanding the characteristics of venal offices and constructing economic models for office prices. Furthermore, this thesis offers wider implications for the use of financial instruments by modern states, assuming that venal offices were sophisticated enough to resemble modern financial assets.

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## Abbreviations and conventions

BnF            Bibliothèque nationale de France, Paris

*Enquête*        Jean-Baptiste Colbert, *États et évaluation, par généralités, de tous les offices de  
judicature et finance*, 2 vols. (Paris, 1665)

### Money

The *livre tournois* was the standard unit of accounting at the time. Each *livre* was worth 20 *sols* or 240 *deniers*.

## Introduction

“Perhaps all the lands of the kingdom, valued at their true worth, could not pay the price of all the judicial and financial offices,” Jean-Baptiste Colbert surmised in his *Avis sur l’annuel*.<sup>1</sup> The acquisition of public office for money was not uncommon in the early modern world, but nowhere was it more prevalent than in France. In the 1520s, Francis I founded the *bureau des parties casuelles* in order—according to Loyseau’s famous phrase—“to serve as a shop for this new commodity”, which initially concerned only financial offices.<sup>2</sup> Venality of judicial offices was formally prohibited.<sup>3</sup> Magistrates being admitted to sovereign courts would swear that they had paid nothing for their offices but had only loaned money to the king.<sup>4</sup> Samuel Pollack’s work on the *Parlement* of Toulouse challenges a teleological narrative of venality’s rise and shows that in the sixteenth century, councillorships were regarded as temporary royal favours in exchange for loans that would be reimbursed.<sup>5</sup> Indeed, royal acts apologising for creating too many judicial offices suggest a monarchy profoundly unsure about venality’s long-term place in the kingdom.<sup>6</sup> Venality responded to a demand from the social body as much as to the needs of the royal treasury.<sup>7</sup> As the value of offices grew to reflect their advantageous returns, it became doubtful whether magistrates would pursue reimbursement for their initial loans.<sup>8</sup> Councillor-reporters in the *sénéchaussée* of Toulouse declared in the 1520s that they did not intend to recover their

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<sup>1</sup> Jean-Baptiste Colbert, *Lettres, instructions et mémoires de Colbert* (Paris, 1861-1873), 6.247.

<sup>2</sup> William Doyle, ‘Colbert et les offices’, *Histoire, économie & société* 19:4 (2000), 470.

<sup>3</sup> Roland Mousnier, *La vénalité des offices sous Henri IV et Louis XIII* (Paris, 1971), 35.

<sup>4</sup> Samuel J. Pollack, *The crown and judicial venality in the Parlement of Toulouse, c. 1490-1547* (D.Phil. thesis, University of Oxford, 2017), 307.

<sup>5</sup> Pollack, *The crown and judicial venality*, 173.

<sup>6</sup> Pollack, *The crown and judicial venality*, 75.

<sup>7</sup> Christophe Blanquie, *Une enquête de Colbert en 1665* (Paris, 2012), 216.

<sup>8</sup> Pollack, *The crown and judicial venality*, 301.

money, but preferred to possess their posts for life.<sup>9</sup> After 1604, with succession rights confirmed by a yearly payment, the *droit annuel* or “paulette”,<sup>10</sup> offices were no longer something resembling collateral for loans but more akin to patrimonial property that served as a source of dignity and income. The valuation of venal offices merits further study, for it reveals the social and political foundations of the *ancien régime* and invites comparison with modern financial securities and public offices.

The *Grand Siècle* witnessed venality in its fullest institutional incarnation. With payment of the paulette, offices became exempt from the Forty Days Rule. This rule reverted an office to the *parties casuelles* if its holder died within forty days after resigning the office for his heir. Premature death would mean losing all the office’s capital, posing a significant risk. With the paulette insuring against this risk, offices became similar to financial securities with stable returns, and their numbers and values steadily rose. The *Enquête* lists 45,780 venal offices in 1665 with a combined value of 420 million *livres*. If one includes the offices of the royal households and the army, total capitalisation approaches 800 million *livres*.<sup>11</sup> Concerned about the capital trapped in illiquid offices, Colbert sought to abolish venality, or failing that, eliminate its principal drawbacks and increase its efficiency.<sup>12</sup> He required precise information, so he ordered the *trésoriers de France* to compile preliminary reports on office values, *gages* (fixed salaries), and *annuel* payments in every *généralité*.<sup>13</sup> Colbert’s clerks revised and finalised these

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<sup>9</sup> Pollack, *The crown and judicial venality*, 301.

<sup>10</sup> Mark Potter, *Corps and clientele: Public finance and political change in France, 1688-1715* (London, 2017), 33.

<sup>11</sup> Doyle, ‘Colbert’, 474.

<sup>12</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 214, 217.

<sup>13</sup> Emilie Bonhoure, Olivier Musy, and Ronan Tallec, ‘Exploring French venality in the seventeenth century: Insights from a new database on offices’, *Historical Methods: A Journal of Quantitative and Interdisciplinary History* 57:2 (2024), 83.

reports before producing the finished *Enquête*, which survives in two volumes: BnF 500 Colbert 259 and 260.<sup>14</sup>

Although these volumes constitute a uniquely rich source of data on venal offices, detailed statistical analysis remains limited. Bonhoure, Musy, and Tallec's recent quantitative study has made significant progress. Their useful descriptive statistics on 15,000 offices open many avenues for future research. The authors rightly observe that the return on office is three-fold and encompasses *gages*, emoluments, and status, but a misreading of their regression would assign disproportionate importance to *gages*.<sup>15</sup> For instance, the results indicate that a one-*livre* increase in *gages* is associated with an average increase in salt-store office prices by 27.878 *livres*, but a one-*livre* increase in emoluments is associated with a price increase of only 7.380 *livres*.<sup>16</sup> As the authors clarify, these descriptive correlations are consistent with characteristics of an efficient market but do not reflect how prices would actually respond to a marginal change in returns. In an efficient market, a one-*livre* increase in *gages* should have the same effect on price as a one-*livre* increase in emoluments, assuming a negligible difference in variability. Therefore, the relative contributions of *gages*, emoluments, and dignity to office valuation remain insufficiently explored, despite the wealth of data in the *Enquête*.

Building upon the formulation of the three-fold return on office, this thesis combines economic models with the *Enquête* to draw general insights about venal offices. Additionally, the models rely on the memoir of Voysin de la Noiraye, an *intendant* who prepared detailed

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<sup>14</sup> Bonhoure, Musy, and Tallec, 'Exploring French venality', 83.

<sup>15</sup> Bonhoure, Musy, and Tallec, 'Exploring French venality', 92.

<sup>16</sup> Bonhoure, Musy, and Tallec, 'Exploring French venality', 92.

memoranda on Normandy to help compile the *Enquête*.<sup>17</sup> Colbert requested *intendants* to draft general memoranda on other *généralités* too, but these have been lost.<sup>18</sup> The model's findings reveal that whereas judicial offices were primarily sources of dignity with low profitability, emoluments were most important to the value of financial offices, especially those that handled major revenue flows; *gages* generally contributed minimally to office values, though the return from *gages* could be significant for the mounted archers of the *marechaussée* or the *receveurs* of woodland revenues. Finally, the highest financial offices consolidated what was effectively a *noblesse de l'argent*, which borrowed from the aristocracy and possessed many *rentes* (annuities), *billets* (treasury notes), *traités* (fiscal contracts), and other capitalised claims on public revenues. In what might be called a privileged creditor overhang problem, administrative fiscal reforms towards improving public finances incurred political and financial costs from privileged creditors—aristocrats, magistrates, and financiers—whose claims would lose value. This model clarifies Colbert's failure to abolish venality and illustrates how the capitalisation of public authority into private property can restrain institutional reform.

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<sup>17</sup> Jean-Baptiste Voysin de la Noiraye, *Mémoire sur la généralité de Rouen* (Paris, 1913), v.

<sup>18</sup> Voysin, *Mémoire*, 162.

## Officers in the society of orders

Any model of venality should first clarify the legal nature of offices, particularly whether they constitute feudal property or private property. Writing in 1610, the Parisian *parlementaire* Charles Loyseau defined office as “dignity with public function”.<sup>19</sup> Loyseau classified dignity as a quality worthy of esteem, like one’s order or *seigneurie*.<sup>20</sup> This seemingly relates offices to feudal property like seigneurial rights, though Loyseau notes that the public function distinguishes offices from other dignities. Modern scholarship likewise associates venal office with quasi-feudal characteristics. Mark Potter calls venal office “a form of feudal property”, in which the officer holds a right to the office but the king retains a competing right in the office, like feudal land tenure.<sup>21</sup> As John J. Hurt shows, the crown never relinquished this right and would regularly compel officeholders to commit additional capital in exchange for augmented *gages*.<sup>22</sup> In this respect, William Beik observes that venality represented “a significant advance over the earlier feudal relationships”.<sup>23</sup> In his study of Brittany, James B. Collins, carefully distinguishing between private and feudal property, concludes that venality is “the sale of public functions into private hands” and “the extension of the basic political element of feudalism”.<sup>24</sup> Mousnier similarly designates venality as “a new form of feudalism”, despite acknowledging

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<sup>19</sup> Charles Loyseau, *Cinq livres du droit des offices* (Châteaudun, 1610), 13.

<sup>20</sup> Loyseau, *Cinq livres*, 14.

<sup>21</sup> Potter, *Corps and clienteles*, 29.

<sup>22</sup> John J. Hurt, *Louis XIV and the parlements: The assertion of royal authority* (Manchester, 2002), 69.

<sup>23</sup> William Beik, *Absolutism and society in seventeenth-century France* (New York, 2011), 44.

<sup>24</sup> James B. Collins, *Classes, estates and order in early modern Brittany* (Cambridge, 2009), 277.

that offices have the legal characteristics of immoveable property and patrimonial assets.<sup>25</sup> The origins of venality partially support this interpretation, since the Capetians first began leasing and selling provostships to avoid the enfeoffment of public office.<sup>26</sup> Venality might be understood as a form of “new feudalism”. Although offices were not traditional seigneurial rights and had attributes of private, income-bearing assets, the king’s eminent right in offices and the private ownership of public power align with fundamental feudal principles. A venal office can be defined succinctly as a dignity, property, and financial security.

Offices can be divided into those of arms, justice, and finance—the three powers symbolised by the three fleurs-de-lis of the crown.<sup>27</sup> This tripartite structure defined the corporate bodies within which officers operated. In Loyseau’s scheme, finance, as the lower fleur-de-lis, was subordinate to justice and arms.<sup>28</sup> Beneath the monarch stood the three principal officers holding the superintendancies of war, justice, and finance.<sup>29</sup> The *Connétable* commanded the royal armies, governors, lieutenants, captains, and *maréchaussées*.<sup>30</sup> The Chancellor presided over the judicial hierarchy, which included the *parlements*, *présidials*, *sénéchaussées*, *bailliages*, and *vicomtés*.<sup>31</sup> The *surintendant des finances* nominally oversaw the *chambres des comptes*, *cours des aides*, *bureaux des finances*, *élections*, and salt storehouses.<sup>32</sup>

By 1665, royal policies had altered this structure. Richelieu abolished the office of *Connétable* in 1627 and redistributed its functions to the four Secretaries of State, who held

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<sup>25</sup> Mousnier, *Vénalité*, 33.

<sup>26</sup> Mousnier, *Vénalité*, 14.

<sup>27</sup> Loyseau, *Cinq livres*, 15.

<sup>28</sup> Loyseau, *Cinq livres*, 16.

<sup>29</sup> Loyseau, *Cinq livres*, 16.

<sup>30</sup> Loyseau, *Cinq livres*, 16.

<sup>31</sup> Loyseau, *Cinq livres*, 16.

<sup>32</sup> Loyseau, *Cinq livres*, 16.

revocable commissions.<sup>33</sup> The Chancellor remained a venal officer but could be circumvented through the Keeper of the Seals, except on those occasions when the same person held both offices.<sup>34</sup> In 1661, Louis XIV arrested the last *surintendant des finances* and replaced the office with the commission of *contrôleur général des finances*.<sup>35</sup> Judicial and financial offices were venal, as were posts within the *maréchaussées*. Military commands like lieutenancies and captaincies were legally commissions, though informal military venality was widely tolerated.<sup>36</sup> Additionally, posts in military administration and war finance—including *commissaires des guerres* and *trésoriers de l'extraordinaire des guerres*—were venal,<sup>37</sup> but they fell outside the provincial corporate structures examined by the *Enquête*. Colbert's *Enquête* was concerned primarily with judicial and financial officer companies within the *généralités*.

An office derives its full value only within the company to which it belongs, for an officer, in Mousnier's words, is a *bête de compagnie*.<sup>38</sup> The term "company" denotes a judicial or administrative body that exercises public authority, distinguishing it from other corporations like universities, academies, and commercial guilds.<sup>39</sup> Royal officers formed communities and companies, which were hierarchically related.<sup>40</sup> *Parlements*, *cours des aides*, and *chambres des comptes* constituted sovereign or superior companies, while the other courts were subordinate.<sup>41</sup>

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<sup>33</sup> Richard Bonney, *The king's debts: finance and politics in France 1589-1661* (Oxford, 1981), 132.

<sup>34</sup> A. Lloyd. Moote, *The revolt of the judges: The parlement of Paris and the Fronde, 1643-1652* (Princeton, 1971), 5.

<sup>35</sup> Bonney, *The king's debts*, 265.

<sup>36</sup> Guy Rowlands, *The dynastic state and the army under Louis XIV: Royal service and private interest, 1661-1701* (Cambridge, 2002), 199.

<sup>37</sup> Rowlands, *The dynastic state*, 30, 133.

<sup>38</sup> Mousnier, *Vénalité*, 576.

<sup>39</sup> Roland Mousnier, *The institutions of France under the absolute monarchy, 1598-1789* (Chicago, 1979), 1.431.

<sup>40</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.431.

<sup>41</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.431.

These hierarchies directly affected an office's dignity and therefore its value: a *présidial* court outranked an *élection*, and a *conseiller* in the former took precedence over the *élus* in the latter.<sup>42</sup>

Internal hierarchies mattered as much as institutional rank. A councillor had an interest in the conduct of the lieutenant-general, because the dignity of each member reflected upon the company as a whole.<sup>43</sup> *Esprit de corps* could enhance the collective authority of a company and the attractiveness and market value of its offices.<sup>44</sup> Conversely, internal divisions could erode prestige and prices.<sup>45</sup> Guy Joly, a Parisian *parlementaire*, describes this dynamic in his memoirs. Twenty councillors in the *Parlement* of Paris had purchased their offices cheaply from Richelieu but were excluded by their colleagues from participating in public administration.<sup>46</sup> Ostracised, their owners struggled to sell the offices, as low corporate standing diminished their value.

This reveals another crucial point: although one could own the right to an office, its exercise required reception by the company. Typically, a *procureur du roi* would conduct an enquiry into the candidate's age, experience, religion, morals, politics, family connections, and occupation.<sup>47</sup> He also checked how much was paid for the office.<sup>48</sup> The *procureur du roi* might decide to reject the candidate for practising a demeaning trade, or for having excessively base connections, or for leading a dissolute life, or for following the Protestant faith, or for lacking age and legal experience.<sup>49</sup> Offices did not exist independently of their companies. To enter the

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<sup>42</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 91.

<sup>43</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 91.

<sup>44</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 91.

<sup>45</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 91.

<sup>46</sup> Guy Joly, *Memoirs of Guy Joli, private secretary to Cardinal de Retz* (Dublin, 1777), 1.37.

<sup>47</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.432.

<sup>48</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.432.

<sup>49</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.432.

company and realise an office's full economic and social value, candidates had to belong to a compatible social milieu.

Officers were drawn from a wide social spectrum, ranging from the provincial aristocrats in the *parlements* to the petty bourgeois in minor administrative posts. The society of orders provides a useful framework to understand how contemporaries like Loyseau ranked these groups according to dignity. Although the Estates General of 1614 formally assigned all officers to the Third Estate,<sup>50</sup> the dignity attached to offices varied enormously. Certain ecclesiastical offices were reserved for clerics, and some offices granted their holders *chevalerie*, membership in the higher nobility.<sup>51</sup> Within the nobility itself stood the princes, the titled *chevaliers*—dukes, marquises, counts, barons—and the broader body of *gentilshommes*.<sup>52</sup> Military service and the right to wear a sword characterised the *noblesse d'épée*, yet by the early seventeenth century, the profession of magistrate had acquired comparable prestige.<sup>53</sup> Men of the robe, not sword-wearing *gentilshommes*, primarily staffed the king's council.<sup>54</sup> The wealth of most *parlementaires* ranged from 150,000–350,000 *livres*. There were a few millionaires and a handful with fortunes above 500,000 *livres*.<sup>55</sup> Although robe nobles constituted a minority within the nobility, they commanded a disproportionate share of political and economic power.<sup>56</sup> As William Beik's analysis of Languedoc demonstrates, among the truly influential powers of the *généralité*, only the archbishop, prelates, and governor outranked the presidents and councillors of the

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<sup>50</sup> Collins, *Classes, estates and order*, 7.

<sup>51</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.11.

<sup>52</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.7.

<sup>53</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.20.

<sup>54</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.20.

<sup>55</sup> Hurt, *Louis XIV and the parlements*, 73.

<sup>56</sup> Jonathan Dewald, *The formation of a provincial nobility: The magistrates of the parlement of Rouen, 1499-1610* (Princeton, 1980), 70.

*parlement*.<sup>57</sup> James B. Collins similarly states that presidents in the *parlements* stood socially alongside *chevaliers* below the rank of duke, while magistrates in the *présidial* courts possessed greater political and economic weight than many untitled *gentilshommes*, even those holding fiefs.<sup>58</sup> In the provincial order of precedence, the *noblesse de robe* formed an aristocracy second only to high ecclesiastics and the most eminent titled nobles.

Outside the sovereign courts, most officers had more modest backgrounds as rentier *bourgeois vivant noblement* or commercial bourgeois. For the clergy, nobility, and higher strata of the bourgeoisie, it was customary to live from *rentes*, seigneurial dues, land rents, pensions, emoluments, and salaries.<sup>59</sup> In principle, wealth from commercial dealings did not confer social elevation, and Loyseau ranked all officers, even short-robed bailiffs, above merchants in dignity.<sup>60</sup> Hence, only the *bourgeois vivant noblement*, who had withdrawn from commerce and adopted a rentier mode of life, were suitable candidates for magistracies. While sons of merchants could enter the *parlements* during the sixteenth century, sovereign courts became increasingly closed off during the seventeenth century, as a handful of dynasties monopolised the most prominent magistracies.<sup>61</sup> In Collins' analysis of seventeenth-century Brittany, judicial families often achieved nobility and intermarried with older noble houses, while most financial officers married endogamously or with the daughters of merchants.<sup>62</sup> Judicial and financial families rarely intermarried, and upward mobility from a financial office to a sovereign court was

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<sup>57</sup> Beik, *Absolutism and society*, 44.

<sup>58</sup> Collins, *Classes, estates and order*, 9.

<sup>59</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.13.

<sup>60</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.7.

<sup>61</sup> Potter, *Corps and clientele*, 65-66.

<sup>62</sup> Collins, *Classes, estates and order*, 9.

uncommon.<sup>63</sup> Only established judicial officer families, drawn from the *bourgeois vivant noblement*, could realistically enter the robe nobility either through marriage or officeholding.

*Bourgeois vivant noblement* belonged to extended families which often included the *bourgeois marchands*, the great wholesale merchants who bought grain, wood, hay, wine, and textiles from the *seigneuries* and resold them in urban markets.<sup>64</sup> These merchants bore the title “*honorable homme, marchand*”,<sup>65</sup> and it was not uncommon for their relatives to hold offices as part of a wider family strategy. In his study of the Colbert clan, Jean-Louis Bourgeon comments,<sup>66</sup> “Any specialisation, even in commerce, limits expansion.” Colbert’s grandparents, Jehan Colbert and Marie Bachelier, placed their sixth son in the Church and purchased for their fifth son the magistracy of lieutenant-general in a *présidial* court.<sup>67</sup> The older sons continued in commerce and banking. As business in Reims declined, the fourth son, Nicolas, moved to Paris.<sup>68</sup> There, one family branch was already involved with officeholding: a cousin of his was a councillor in the *parlement*, another was married to the daughter of a councillor in the *cour des aides*, and a third was preparing to purchase the ennobling office of *secrétaire du roi*.<sup>69</sup> Nicolas, father to Jean-Baptiste Colbert, transitioned from cloth merchant to financier, handling the king’s money in various offices—*receveur des aides et tailles de Forez* (1621), *receveur général et payeur des rentes constituées sur la ferme des aides* (1635), and *receveur des consignations* (1642).<sup>70</sup> The Colberts exemplify an upper bourgeois dynasty with branches extending into commerce, offices, and the Church.

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<sup>63</sup> Collins, *Classes, estates and order*, 9.

<sup>64</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.241.

<sup>65</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.241.

<sup>66</sup> Jean-Louis Bourgeon, *Les Colbert avant Colbert: Destin d’une famille marchande* (Paris, 1973), 138.

<sup>67</sup> Bourgeon, *Les Colbert*, 135.

<sup>68</sup> Bourgeon, *Les Colbert*, 169.

<sup>69</sup> Bourgeon, *Les Colbert*, 170.

<sup>70</sup> Bourgeon, *Les Colbert*, 9.

In seventeenth-century Beauvais, leading merchants belonged to the same extended kin networks as officers in the *présidial* court, *élection*, and salt storehouse.<sup>71</sup> These officers possessed fortunes ranging from 60,000–100,000 *livres*. Wholesale merchants had comparable fortunes between 35,000 and 110,000 *livres*, with the wealthiest possessing 400,000–500,000 *livres*.<sup>72</sup> The officers followed the rentier lifestyle with a large share of their property invested in land instead of stocks of goods and credit.<sup>73</sup> They belonged to a higher stratum in the society of orders and were better positioned for further social advancement, especially as judicial officer families became increasingly endogamous. The *bourgeois vivant noblement* and *bourgeois marchands* can be understood as two branches of the upper bourgeoisie, one oriented towards officeholding and the other towards commerce.

Numerically, most officers were recruited from the middling bourgeois and petty bourgeois. Those styled *honorable hommes* occupied many intermediate and minor offices, such as the *procureurs* in the *parlements* and *présidial* courts, the *grenetiers* of the salt storehouses, and regulated brokers within urban *police* jurisdictions.<sup>74</sup> Advancement was often gradual and multigenerational. Only over several generations might a family rise from the modest post of *procureur* to the magistracy of lieutenant-general in the *bailliage*.<sup>75</sup> During this time, it would have progressively changed the composition of its fortune toward landed property, conforming to the rentier lifestyle.<sup>76</sup> Alternatively, it might aim for the financial office of *receveur des tailles* in the *élection*, about as equally costly but perhaps more remunerative. Mousnier's dowry data for

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<sup>71</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.223.

<sup>72</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.223, 1.242.

<sup>73</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.223.

<sup>74</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.244.

<sup>75</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.239.

<sup>76</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.245.

*honorable hommes*, ranging from 2,000–12,000 *livres*, suggests they likely possessed fortunes between 10,000 and 60,000 *livres*.<sup>77</sup>

Below the *honorable hommes* stood the *honnêtes personnes*, a more modest but not impoverished bourgeoisie of master craftsmen, small shopkeepers, and minor clerks.<sup>78</sup> Their fortunes were roughly between 3,000 and 15,000 *livres*, comparable to those of richer tenant-farmers. A range of cheaper offices was accessible to this stratum: *huissiers* and *sergents* in *bailliages* and *vicomtés*, clerks in salt storehouses, archers in *marechaussées*, inspectors and appraisers. Such offices cost around a thousand *livres*, roughly the value of a house or small farm.<sup>79</sup> The wide array of offices offered respectable and petty bourgeois families numerous avenues of advancement at multiple price levels,<sup>80</sup> enabling them to acquire a public dignity that surpassed that of wealthy merchants within the hierarchy of orders.

In this chapter, we have seen that an office encompassed a dignity, property, and security after 1604. Just as *una apis nulla apis*, an office realised its full economic and social value within a wider corporate body of officers. Their integration into society's upper orders reveals that seventeenth-century venality was not just a means of public credit born of the exigencies of war. Rather, it was the financial concretisation of social and political relationships.<sup>81</sup> Structurally embedded within the civil administration, officers tied society together at the elite levels. Christophe Blanquie describes venality as a sailing ship.<sup>82</sup> The heights and positions of the masts correspond to the hierarchy between officer companies, while the rigging that secures each office

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<sup>77</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.243–244.

<sup>78</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.8, 1.244.

<sup>79</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 89.

<sup>80</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 89.

<sup>81</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 214.

<sup>82</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 202.

in place encompasses prices, *gages*, dignity, and emoluments. Officers climb the masts as cabin boys, and Colbert, the reluctant captain, evaluates the whole system's cohesion. This extended metaphor captures how venality comprises multiple, interdependent hierarchies, the stability of which depends upon the balance of the whole. Chapter 2 therefore turns to consider office prices and returns, using a model of judicial offices.

## The dignity of the judges

To construct a model for the valuation of judicial offices, it is necessary to adopt a number of assumptions. These assumptions, albeit plausible, may not always hold in practice, and some deserve scrutiny. Nonetheless, without them, the model cannot function or produce general insights into the economics of officeholding.

First, the model assumes that the *prix courant* recorded in the *Enquête* approximates an office's intrinsic value—that is, its administratively assessed capital value rather than the latest market transaction price. The *trésoriers de France* could not determine prices to the *sol* and *denier*, nor did they reproduce observed sales prices.<sup>83</sup> Vacant offices and offices long retained by particular families had no recent transactions.<sup>84</sup> Even when receipts existed, they did not necessarily represent value accurately, as market prices could be temporarily inflated or depressed.<sup>85</sup> As royal officers and knowledgeable experts in venal offices, the *trésoriers* were expected to correct misleading figures for Colbert.<sup>86</sup> Appropriately, they preferred the term “*prix par estimation*”.<sup>87</sup> This indicates that the *prix courant* represented not a spot market price but an assessment of intrinsic value, based on points of reference such as rank, income, and the 1638

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<sup>83</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 98.

<sup>84</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 26.

<sup>85</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 108.

<sup>86</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 108.

<sup>87</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 99.

*évaluation*.<sup>88</sup> The fact that *prix courants* appear to underestimate office prices in the *parlements* by roughly 10–15% corroborates this.<sup>89</sup>

The *évaluation* served as a basis for fiscal accounting. When the *paulette* was introduced in 1604, the crown assigned each non-hereditary office an *évaluation*, and the *annuel* was fixed at one-sixtieth of this amount.<sup>90</sup> As officers increasingly adopted the *paulette* and office prices rose, the crown raised the *évaluations* by one-third in 1638.<sup>91</sup> These *évaluations* were not intended to reflect prevailing market prices or intrinsic values. They functioned instead as administrative benchmarks for taxation.<sup>92</sup> For each office, the *Enquête* lists the 1638 *évaluation* and corresponding *annuel*, alongside the *prix courant*. This placement reveals one of the *Enquête*'s practical purposes: it exposes the divergence between an office's current assessed value and its fiscal base, providing the crown with the information to adjust the *annuel* accordingly.<sup>93</sup>

A more fundamental assumption concerns market efficiency. If market agents formed rational expectations—beliefs that are correct on average—then office prices should reflect available information and thereby approximate intrinsic value. Pertinent information on offices would include their dignity, *gages*, emoluments, taxes, exemptions, and operating expenses. As the market for offices encompassed socially interconnected nobles and bourgeois, buyers and sellers of offices were plausibly well-informed, though informational asymmetries likely existed.

Incumbent officeholders probably possessed better knowledge of their emoluments than

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<sup>88</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 106.

<sup>89</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 207.

<sup>90</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 25.

<sup>91</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 25.

<sup>92</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 25.

<sup>93</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 26.

prospective purchasers, implying the market exhibited semi-strong efficiency at best rather than full informational efficiency.<sup>94</sup> Nonetheless, empirical evidence indicates at least partial market efficiency. Bonhoure, Musy, and Tallec demonstrate that *gages*, emoluments, and status are positively correlated with office prices, suggesting that prices captured observable income and rank.<sup>95</sup> Moreover, although the *noblesse de robe* and *bourgeois vivant noblement* valued honour, a taste for honour did not eclipse financial considerations.<sup>96</sup> The accounts of magistrates such as Alexis Chorion and Charles Maignart devote considerable attention to the costs, revenues, and profits of rural estates.<sup>97</sup> As Jonathan Dewald argues, surviving evidence—albeit biased towards wealthier families—indicates that *parlementaires* managed landed properties in a rational, calculating, and profit-oriented manner.<sup>98</sup> It is reasonable to suppose that they devoted similar attention to the profitability of offices, long-term assets worth as much as rural estates. This provides some basis for modelling the venal market as broadly efficient, even if not perfectly so.

The dividend discount model provides a framework for estimating the intrinsic value of an office. The price  $P_t$  corresponds to the sum of future expected dividends  $E[D_{t+j}]$ , discounted by the required rate of return  $r_{required}$ .<sup>99</sup> In this context, dividends comprise the office's *gages*, emoluments, and dignity. The required return accounts for time discounting, asset-specific risk, and risk preferences.<sup>100</sup> Before 1604, the required return would have been greater to compensate for the risk of losing the office under the Forty Days Rule. After the paulette insured against this

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<sup>94</sup> On informational efficiency, see; Richard A. Brealey, Stewart C. Myers, and Franklin Allen, *Principles of Corporate Finance* (New York, 2020), 340.

<sup>95</sup> Bonhoure, Musy, and Tallec, 'Exploring French venality', 93.

<sup>96</sup> Philip T. Hoffman, *Growth in a traditional society: The French countryside, 1450-1815* (Princeton, 2000), 64.

<sup>97</sup> Hoffman, *Growth*, 64; Dewald, *Formation of a provincial nobility*, 184.

<sup>98</sup> Dewald, *Formation of a provincial nobility*, 185.

<sup>99</sup> Brealey, Myers, and Allen, *Principles*, 85.

<sup>100</sup> Brealey, Myers, and Allen, *Principles*, 173.

risk, offices became closer to perpetuities with relatively stable yields. Prices rose, as the required return diminished.

Formally,

$$P_t = \sum_{j=1}^{\infty} \frac{E[D_{t+j}]}{(1+r_{\text{required}})^j}$$

For convenience, suppose expected dividends are constant:  $E[D_{t+j}] = D$ . The model reduces to the standard perpetuity formula.<sup>101</sup>

$$P_t = \frac{D}{r_{\text{required}}}$$

In a semi-efficient market, prices adjust so that agents earn on average the required return, though thin trading and liquidity constraints may generate deviations.<sup>102</sup> We use the legal interest rate on new *rentes* as a benchmark for the required return on stable, patrimonial offices. Between 1634 and 1665, this rate was *denier* 18 (~5.556%).<sup>103</sup> The crown did not always reliably service *rentes*. Nonetheless, the king's *denier* provides a reference rate for long-term capital.<sup>104</sup> More credible institutions, like the Estates of Burgundy, issued *rentes* with often similar yields.<sup>105</sup> Because officers also paid the *paulette*, the gross return on an office must equal the *rente* rate

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<sup>101</sup> Brealey, Myers, and Allen, *Principles*, 28.

<sup>102</sup> Brealey, Myers, and Allen, *Principles*, 340.

<sup>103</sup> Bonney, *The king's debts*, 19.

<sup>104</sup> Hoffman, *Growth*, 215.

<sup>105</sup> Potter, *Corps and clientele*, 159.

plus the *annuel* rate  $\alpha$ . The intuition is straightforward: agents can allocate capital between offices and *rentes*, so offices must compensate for the benchmark rate and the *annuel* to remain attractive. This benchmark applies primarily to stable judicial and administrative offices. Financial offices with greater income volatility would require additional risk premia, to be examined in the following chapter.

$$r_{required} = r_{rente} + \alpha = r_{office}$$

$$P_t = \frac{D}{r_{required}} = \frac{g+e+d}{r_{rente}+\alpha}$$

$$r_{office} = \frac{D}{P} = r_{gages} + r_{emoluments} + r_{dignity}$$

The return on office has three components: *gages*  $g$ , emoluments  $e$ , and dignity  $d$ .<sup>106</sup> *Gages* and emoluments comprise the pecuniary return, while dignity captures the non-pecuniary benefits of rank, honour, and social distinction that were capitalised into prices. Certain prestigious offices also conferred tax exemptions, which varied in value. Those with at least second-generation nobility were already exempt from the principal land tax, the *taille*, irrespective of officeholding. In privileged towns like Rouen, residents were also *taille*-exempt provided they did not own rural property.<sup>107</sup> For these groups, fiscal privileges from officeholding contributed little to their after-tax income. Tax exemptions were more significant for the bourgeois in parishes under the *taille*, yet the intermediate and minor offices accessible to this strata usually came without fiscal privileges. Royal officers of meaningful rank also enjoyed

<sup>106</sup> Bonhoure, Musy, and Tallec, ‘Exploring French venality’, 82.

<sup>107</sup> Voysin, *Mémoire*, 137.

*franc-salé*, an annual allowance of untaxed salt, typically one *minot*.<sup>108</sup> However, the crown frequently found alternative means of taxing officers: the *marc d'or*, amortisation duties, transfer duties, stamped paper taxes, the *capitation*, and the *dixième*, which would become the *vingtième*.<sup>109</sup> Given the uneven value of exemptions across officers and the crown's use of alternative taxes, the baseline model does not account for office-specific tax privileges except when exemptions prove significant.

Emoluments were typically the principal source of pecuniary return, though *gages* were equally significant in Rouen's *chambre des comptes*.<sup>110</sup> Judicial officers received what were colloquially called *épices*—well-structured and regulated litigation fees. A table of emoluments from the *sénéchaussée* and *présidial* court of Nîmes in 1700 lists nearly fifty fees for routine procedures, including 10 *sols* for administering witnesses, 5 *sols* for pleading before the court, and 10 *sols* for filing petitions (see Appendix Figure 1). Given that the average day-labourer might earn roughly 5–10 *sols* for a summer day's work, litigation was costly, even if fees were perhaps lower in peacetime.<sup>111</sup> Some fees were earmarked for specific officers, like the *greffiers* who received 10 *sols* for each *requête introductive* presented to the court.<sup>112</sup> Most fees went into the company's common fund, from which each officer took a share.<sup>113</sup> Combining Colbert's *Enquête* with Voysin's memoranda makes it possible to estimate the required return on offices in

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<sup>108</sup> A 1694 edict grants new *contrôleurs* one *minot* of *franc-salé*, suggesting this was standard for mid- to upper-tier judicial officers; *Édit du roy, portant création des offices de contrôleurs des taxes de dépens des conseils, parlemens, cours supérieures, présidiaux, bailliages, sénéchaussées et autres justices royales..., avec attribution de 18 et 6 deniers pour livre des taxes des dépens...* (Paris, 1694), 8.

<sup>109</sup> On the *dixième*, see: Gary B. McCollim, *Louis XIV's assault on privilege: Nicolas Desmaretz and the tax on wealth* (Cambridge, 2023), 225–226.

<sup>110</sup> See Appendix Tables 3 and 5.

<sup>111</sup> Pierre Goubert, *The French peasantry in the seventeenth century* (Cambridge, 1986), 100.

<sup>112</sup> See Appendix Figure 1.

<sup>113</sup> Voysin, *Mémoire*, 83.

Normandy and the pecuniary return from *gages* and emoluments; the remaining residual is interpreted as the return from dignity.

The model indicates that magistrate offices had very low pecuniary returns relative to their capitalised values, implying the greater portion of their yield derived from dignity.<sup>114</sup> The *Enquête* values the office of *conseiller laïc* (lay councillor) in the *Parlement* of Rouen at 88,000 *livres*.<sup>115</sup> With 66 such offices, their aggregate value amounted to 5,808,000 *livres*, 50% of the total capitalised value of all offices in the *parlement*.<sup>116</sup> A *conseiller laïc* in the *Grand Chambre* could expect to receive a 0.26% return from *gages* and a 0.68% return from emoluments. The total pecuniary return equals 0.94%, far below the required return of 5.93% derived from the *rente* benchmark plus the *annuel* rate.<sup>117</sup> For comparison, yields on land were declining in this period to less than 3%.<sup>118</sup> Even if a *conseiller* received a generous commission every year, the pecuniary return on office would rise to around 3%, still well below the required return. Moreover, many *conseillers* were assigned to the *Chambre des Enquêtes*, which had a smaller common fund and would have reduced the pecuniary return to 0.37%.<sup>119</sup> Returning to the *Grand Chambre*, the gap between the required return and pecuniary return, approximately 4.99 percentage points, represents the residual.<sup>120</sup> In proportional terms, 84% of the office's equilibrium annual yield is unexplained by *gages* or emoluments and can therefore be attributable to dignity.<sup>121</sup>

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<sup>114</sup> For the full mathematics, see Appendix Table 2.

<sup>115</sup> BnF 500 Colbert 260, folio 181.

<sup>116</sup> See Appendix Table 1.

<sup>117</sup> See Appendix Table 2.

<sup>118</sup> Pierre Goubert, *Louis XIV and Twenty Million Frenchmen* (New York, 1970), 184.

<sup>119</sup> See Appendix Table 2.

<sup>120</sup> See Appendix Table 2.

<sup>121</sup> See Appendix Tables 2.

The remaining offices in the *parlement* exhibit a similar structure. Returns from *gages* are around 0–2%, clustering near the lower bound.<sup>122</sup> If one applies the 0.68% emolument return observed for *conseillers* in the *Grand Chambre* as a baseline, the residual return attributable to dignity ranges from 3–7%.<sup>123</sup> However, higher-ranking officers likely received lower percentage returns from emoluments. Voysin notes that in Normandy’s *chambre des comptes*, *présidents* received one-and-a-half times the share of *maîtres des comptes*, who themselves received one-and-a-half times that of *auditeurs*.<sup>124</sup> Yet, the office of *président* cost twice that of a *maître*, which itself was valued at more than twice that of an *auditeur*.<sup>125</sup> Prices increased by more than emoluments did, meaning the yield from emoluments declined with rank. For low-rank officers, a greater pecuniary yield compensated for the lesser return from dignity. This pattern extended to the hierarchy between companies. The *maîtres des comptes* and *auditeurs*, whose offices comprised two-thirds of the aggregate value of their company, earned better pecuniary returns than the *conseillers*, approximated by the model at 2.4% and 3.7% compared to 0.94%.<sup>126</sup> A *parlementaire*’s superior return from dignity compensated for an inferior monetary return, because the *parlement* took precedence over the *chambre des comptes* just as a *président* did over a *maître*.

Evidence from the *bailliage* and *présidial* court of Rouen supports this pattern. *Conseillers* there earned a 0.2% return from *gages* and a 1.66–3.33% return from emoluments, implying a residual dignity component of 3.33–5%.<sup>127</sup> Pecuniary returns were higher in the *présidial* court than in the *Parlement*, though dignity still comprised most of the required

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<sup>122</sup> See Appendix Table 3.

<sup>123</sup> See Appendix Table 3.

<sup>124</sup> Voysin, *Mémoire*, 84.

<sup>125</sup> See Appendix Table 5.

<sup>126</sup> See Appendix Tables 2, 4, 5.

<sup>127</sup> See Appendix Tables 6.

return.<sup>128</sup> Across ordinary *bailliages* and *vicomtés*, the magistracies of lieutenant-general and *vicomte* varied greatly in price, reflecting differences in judicial activity, emoluments, and local prestige.<sup>129</sup> Nonetheless, as they had low returns from *gages* between 0–1%, the magistracies likely shared a comparable composition of returns, with dignity accounting for a significant share of total yield.<sup>130</sup>

These results are consistent with the observation made by the *parlementaire* La Roche Flavin that even with considerable effort, magistrates could hardly achieve a 2–3% monetary return on their offices, and only a small minority of particularly rapacious individuals might earn a profit in the *parlements*.<sup>131</sup> An avaricious magistrate might achieve a more profitable return by lending his services to the great aristocracy.<sup>132</sup> The town of Dieppe was said to belong to the archbishop of Rouen, who had in his pocket a lieutenant-general, a *lieutenant particulier*, and a *procureur*.<sup>133</sup> Nevertheless, for those magistrates who lacked aristocratic patronage, their pecuniary return on office was less than half the rate on *rentes*. When considering that a decent legal education might cost upwards of 12,000 *livres*, the yield appears even less attractive.<sup>134</sup>

Incorporating tax privileges does not alter this conclusion. Based on *capitation* rankings, a *taille* exemption for first-generation *conseillers* who were not *chevaliers ex officio* might save 200–250 *livres*, worth a 0.28% return on an investment of around 88,000 *livres*.<sup>135</sup> For the

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<sup>128</sup> See Appendix Tables 6 and 7.

<sup>129</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 200.

<sup>130</sup> See Appendix Table 8.

<sup>131</sup> Dewald, *Formation of a provincial nobility*, 132.

<sup>132</sup> Dewald, *Formation of a provincial nobility*, 146.

<sup>133</sup> Voysin, *Mémoire*, 144.

<sup>134</sup> Dewald, *Formation of a provincial nobility*, 133.

<sup>135</sup> (*Arrêt du conseil des Finances portant*) *tarif contenant la distribution des classes et le règlement des taxes de la capitation générale* (Paris, 1695), 4–5.

sovereign courts, rights to firewood and *franc-salé* might add another 100–150 *livres*, relatively insignificant.<sup>136</sup> Magistrates in the ordinary courts received probably one *minot* of *franc-salé*, which saved roughly 30 *livres*.<sup>137</sup> A *taille* exemption for a middling bourgeois magistrate might be worth 20–75 *livres*.<sup>138</sup> Together, such privileges would represent at most a 1% return on a magistracy, which cost 10,000 *livres* at minimum.<sup>139</sup> Minor offices typically lacked tax exemptions, but the archers in the *maréchaussées* were an exception. Although their required return would be higher due to the expenses of maintaining a horse, a *taille* exemption of perhaps 60 *livres* for a petty bourgeois would represent a 5% return on the office of *archer ancien*, which cost 1,200 *livres* in the *bailliage* of Gisors.<sup>140</sup> In Normandy's *greniers à sel*, salt-measurers owned offices valued at around 200–600 *livres* and earned approximately a 1–3% return from their emoluments of 2 *deniers* per *minot* of salt.<sup>141</sup> Their gratuity of one-quarter of *franc-salé* would have saved roughly 7.5 *livres*, adding another 1.25–3.75% to the return on office. Nevertheless, for high-value judicial offices, fiscal privileges did not materially reduce the large residual attributable to dignity.

One might reasonably ask why a noble or bourgeois household would retain a judicial office when the capital value might comprise a third of the family fortune yet yield inferior monetary returns. Many *parlementaire* families had originally acquired their offices at relatively low cost during the sixteenth century, earning an 8–15% monetary return on initial investments of 5,000–10,000 *livres*.<sup>142</sup> Yet, robe families were not exchanging their offices for *rentes* at higher

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<sup>136</sup> Dewald, *Formation of a provincial nobility*, 335.

<sup>137</sup> See Appendix Table 9.

<sup>138</sup> James B. Collins, *Fiscal limits of absolutism: Direct taxation in early seventeenth-century France* (London, 1988), 174–175.

<sup>139</sup> See Appendix Table 8.

<sup>140</sup> BnF 500 Colbert 260, folio 201.

<sup>141</sup> See Appendix Table 15.

<sup>142</sup> Pollack, *The crown and judicial venality*, 300.

pecuniary rates in 1665. Dynastic officeholding implies office generated a significant non-monetary return, classified by the model as dignity. Ennoblement comprised part of this return, but it cannot explain why families that already possessed hereditary nobility nonetheless retained ennobling magistracies. As discussed in Chapter 1, the robe nobility ranked among the most influential figures within the *généralités*. They belonged to the provincial aristocracy and controlled matters of civil administration. The *Parlement* of Rouen at times asserted command over military forces, encroaching upon the authority of the *lieutenants du roi*.<sup>143</sup> To sell a magistracy was to relinquish the levers of power and to resign one's membership in society's upper ranks.

Social and political precedence represented the return from dignity. The function of the judge, fully compatible with nobility, carried sacerdotal characteristics. As shown by a portrait of *avocat général* Omer Talon, the magistrates' long robes mirrored those of the clergy and evoked images of gravitas and mature self-restraint.<sup>144</sup> This seniority corresponded with the customary order of precedence in sitting and walking. *Gentilshommes* yielded before royal officers, and *chevaliers* under the rank of prince gave way to those officers who were, *ex officio*, *chevaliers* themselves.<sup>145</sup> In Rouen Cathedral, the *parlement* occupied the foremost seats during public ceremonies like the celebratory *Te Deums*.<sup>146</sup> The *chambre des comptes* secured some seats on the left-hand side, while its rival for precedence, the *cour des aides*, was relegated to a separate chapel.<sup>147</sup> Beyond ceremonial preeminence, the officers of the sovereign courts enjoyed the legal privilege of *committimus*, which brought any civil cases involving them before a superior court

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<sup>143</sup> Voysin, *Mémoire*, 80.

<sup>144</sup> Dewald, *Formation of a provincial nobility*, 22; see Appendix Figure 2.

<sup>145</sup> Mousnier, *Institutions*, 1.9.

<sup>146</sup> Voysin, *Mémoire*, 84–85.

<sup>147</sup> Voysin, *Mémoire*, 84–85.

rather than an ordinary *bailliage* or first-instance court.<sup>148</sup> Strong *esprit de corps* made individuals from judicial families almost legally untouchable.<sup>149</sup> Additionally, the *parlements* exercised the prerogative of registering royal legislation. They could add or delete provisions or refuse the registration altogether.<sup>150</sup> While the crown could force registration through a *lit de justice*, this risked diminishing respect for royal authority.<sup>151</sup> Therefore, the crown often negotiated with the *parlementaires*, whose oratory repeatedly cast themselves as guardians of social peace.<sup>152</sup> Like the priesthood, judicial office conferred social and political preeminences, and the dignity of the robe accounted for most of its value.

Robe families diversified into military offices too, especially for younger sons. Rising military office prices in the 1680s partly reflected increased demand for colonelcies, captaincies, and lieutenancies from the robe nobility.<sup>153</sup> In 1689, the crown set price ceilings of 22,500 *livres* for non-royal cavalry regiments and 36,000 *livres* for dragoons. Prices varied considerably and could exceed twice the supposed maximum for elite units and royal cavalry.<sup>154</sup> While military commissions conferred prestige and honour, they involved net pecuniary losses and greater risks. The crown did not always reliably pay military officers, shifting army maintenance costs onto them.<sup>155</sup> Unlike venal offices, military commissions were legally revocable, so the crown could choose to disband a regiment or refuse to transmit a commission to an heir.<sup>156</sup> While informal military venality enjoyed greater security under Louis XIV than under the cardinal-ministers,<sup>157</sup>

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<sup>148</sup> Marcel Marion, *Dictionnaire des institutions de la France aux XVIIe et XVIIIe siècles* (Paris, 1923), 122.

<sup>149</sup> Marion, *Dictionnaire*, 120.

<sup>150</sup> Dewald, *Formation of a provincial nobility*, 46.

<sup>151</sup> Moote, *Revolt of the judges*, 34.

<sup>152</sup> Dewald, *Formation of a provincial nobility*, 35.

<sup>153</sup> Rowlands, *The dynastic state*, 169.

<sup>154</sup> Rowlands, *The dynastic state*, 169.

<sup>155</sup> Rowlands, *The dynastic state*, 167.

<sup>156</sup> Rowlands, *The dynastic state*, 167–168.

<sup>157</sup> Rowlands, *The dynastic state*, 199.

military posts entailed higher risks and costs than judicial offices, which at least assured a net pecuniary gain and property rights.

More importantly, military rank could not substitute for the political prominence and social ascendancy attached to offices in the sovereign courts and the ordinary judicature. Judicial offices encapsulated Loyseau's definition of "dignity with public function".<sup>158</sup> The elevated value of a magistracy did not reflect expected income so much as its enduring political and social authority.

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<sup>158</sup> Loyseau, *Cinq livres*, 13.

## Financiers and privileged creditors

The valuation of financial offices requires a revised methodology. Officers who were primary receivers gathered funds from the populace, borrowed with their credit, and made regular, fixed payments to secondary receivers like *trésoriers*.<sup>159</sup> Primary receivers with substantial arrears could lose all their property. When the *receveurs généraux des finances* for the Limoges *généralité*, Claude Cointereau and Noël de La Ville, fell behind on their payments and took flight in 1681, the *contrôle général des finances* seized all their property and sold their offices.<sup>160</sup> The required rate of return would have been higher to compensate for the serious risk of bankruptcy. While it would be impossible to determine the precise rate, a suitable baseline might be the interest rate on certain loans contracted by the crown. In 1661, rates on loan contracts had fallen from around 15% to 10.4%.<sup>161</sup> Since the crown often borrowed from *receveurs*, *trésoriers*, and other financiers, 10.4% would be an appropriate benchmark rate, as financial officers could substitute capital between offices and loan contracts. To approximate the required return, the model adds a benchmark rate of 10.4% to the *annuel* rate. Subtracting from the required return the pecuniary yield produces a residual return attributable to dignity.

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<sup>159</sup> McCollim, *Assault on privilege*, 28.

<sup>160</sup> Daniel Dessert, *Argent, pouvoir, et société au Grand Siècle* (Paris, 1984), 53–54.

<sup>161</sup> Bonney, *The king's debts*, 318.

First-degree receivers typically enjoyed a proportional allowance on funds to be gathered. In 1662, the crown allocated nine *deniers* per *livre* to the *receveurs généraux* and *receveurs particuliers* who collected the *taille*, *taillon*, and other *impositions* (direct taxes).<sup>162</sup> Of these nine *deniers*, *receveurs particuliers* earned four *deniers* or a 1.667% allowance, and *receveurs généraux* received the other five or 2.083%.<sup>163</sup> Proportional allowance normally ranged from 4–11 *deniers*.<sup>164</sup> In 1706, the *receveurs* were taking up to five *sols* per *livre*, 25% of *impositions*, as accounting deteriorated during the War of Spanish Succession.<sup>165</sup> The government had not been checking the accounts from 1700–1714 to sustain public confidence in the creditworthiness of its financiers, who lent their credit to the crown and collected royal money.<sup>166</sup> However, Colbert was regularly checking the accounts of primary receivers, so they could not easily pocket more than their legally allotted allowances.<sup>167</sup>

The allowance was levied on the tax assessment before deducting expenses and accrued to the officer exercising the post for the year. An *élection*, a fiscal-administrative district, typically had two *receveurs des tailles*. In 1665, Normandy had three offices of *receveur général des finances*.<sup>168</sup> The year of exercise would alternate between officers. In 1709, Paulin Prondre, *receveur général des finances* for Lyon, ceded his year of exercise to Noel Rousseau, a receiver and payer of *rentes* on the *Hôtel de Ville*.<sup>169</sup> The total tax imposed on the Lyon *généralité* was

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<sup>162</sup> *Édit du roy, portant attribution aux receveurs généraux des finances et receveurs particuliers des tailles, de 9 deniers pour livre de taxations héréditaires des charges ordinaires et extraordinaires assignées sur les recettes générales et particulières...* (Paris, 1696), 1.

<sup>163</sup> *Édit du roy, portant attribution aux receveurs généraux des finances*, 2.

<sup>164</sup> Guy Rowlands, *The financial decline of a great power: War, influence, and money in Louis XIV's France* (Oxford, 2012), 59.

<sup>165</sup> *Édit du roy, portant attribution aux receveurs généraux des finances*, 1.

<sup>166</sup> McCollim, *Assault on privilege*, 32.

<sup>167</sup> McCollim, *Assault on privilege*, 32.

<sup>168</sup> BnF 500 Colbert 260, folios 182–183, 190–194.

<sup>169</sup> McCollim, *Assault on privilege*, 28.

1,380,510 *livres*.<sup>170</sup> Expenses deducted 679,491 *livres*, which included 57,521 *livres* for Rousseau's right to 10 *deniers* per *livre* on the total tax.<sup>171</sup> He paid the Keeper of the Royal Treasury the remaining 701,019 *livres* in fifteen monthly instalments of 46,734 *livres*.<sup>172</sup> *Taillables* paid the parish collectors, who themselves passed the funds to the local *receveurs des tailles*, who in turn moved the money to the *receveur général*.<sup>173</sup> During the rough process of tax collection, the local *receveurs* often had to return to parishes multiple times with *huissiers* and archers to collect what was owed.<sup>174</sup> They would intimidate those with substantial arrears, seize their property, and threaten them with the lodging of troops.<sup>175</sup> Nonetheless, in the long run, most of the money was paid, especially after Colbert had instituted more severe measures.<sup>176</sup>

With Voysin's fiscal statistics, the model approximates the return from emoluments on primary receiver offices in Normandy, assuming that all taxes were paid in the long run and that emoluments comprised only the legally allotted allowances. A *receveur général des finances* earned 15,849 *livres* of average emoluments per year from exercising the office triennially.<sup>177</sup> At 100,000 *livres*, the office's value exceeded that of a councillorship in the *parlement*.<sup>178</sup> Emoluments constituted a 15.849% yield, in addition to a 2.9% return from *gages*.<sup>179</sup> The pecuniary return would surpass the model's estimated required return, suggesting that the return from dignity was negligible. Indeed, the *Enquête* ranked the *receveurs généraux* around the

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<sup>170</sup> McCollim, *Assault on privilege*, 32.

<sup>171</sup> McCollim, *Assault on privilege*, 32.

<sup>172</sup> McCollim, *Assault on privilege*, 32.

<sup>173</sup> McCollim, *Assault on privilege*, 32.

<sup>174</sup> Goubert, *French peasantry*, 198.

<sup>175</sup> Goubert, *French peasantry*, 198.

<sup>176</sup> Goubert, *French peasantry*, 198.

<sup>177</sup> See Appendix Table 12.

<sup>178</sup> BnF 500 Colbert 260, folio 183.

<sup>179</sup> See Appendix Table 12.

middle of the *bureau des finances*, despite their office values being the highest.<sup>180</sup> Emoluments outweighed *gages*, though the 2,900 *livres* of annualised *gages* dwarfed those of any other officer except the *premier président* of the *parlement*.<sup>181</sup> The *gages* likely supported creditworthiness, allowing the *receveurs généraux* to borrow up to 58,000 *livres* at 5% rates when necessary. The 18.749% pecuniary yield far exceeded the monetary return on judicial office, justifying the risk financiers faced.

*Receveurs généraux* practised complex forms of ownership that resembled investments in commercial enterprises. Although a 1670 edict prohibited accumulating several offices of *receveurs généraux*, some individuals obtained exemptions.<sup>182</sup> Samuel Dalies held all three offices of the Grenoble *généralité*, which would have cost around 81,000 *livres*.<sup>183</sup> These were relatively inexpensive compared to the three general receiverships in Normandy, valued at 300,000 *livres* together.<sup>184</sup> Sometimes, financiers pooled their capital to own general receiverships jointly, splitting them into shares. In 1670, Prosper Bauyn, André Bauyn, and Bénigne Dujardin entered into a partnership for the general receiverships for the Montauban *généralité*.<sup>185</sup> Initially owning 16 out of the 20 *sols* that made up the association, Prosper bought out André's three *sols* and Dujardin's one *sol* in 1677.<sup>186</sup> These fractional shares in offices resembled shares in commercial enterprises. Moreover, owners and managers could be separate. Mignot, widow to the *receveur général* for the Grenoble *généralité*, retained the offices and had them administered by clerks.<sup>187</sup> This practice extended to the *élections*. In 1693, Claude Luillier,

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<sup>180</sup> BnF 500 Colbert 260, folios 182–183.

<sup>181</sup> BnF 500 Colbert 260, folios 181–205.

<sup>182</sup> Dessert, *Argent*, 47.

<sup>183</sup> Dessert, *Argent*, 47; BnF 500 Colbert 259, folio 226.

<sup>184</sup> BnF 500 Colbert 260, folio 183.

<sup>185</sup> Dessert, *Argent*, 48.

<sup>186</sup> Dessert, *Argent*, 48.

<sup>187</sup> Dessert, *Argent*, 49.

who nominally held the local receivership for the *élection* of Aurillac, exercised the office on behalf of its true owners, Rambouillet de Lancey and Prondre.<sup>188</sup> It would be difficult to imagine similar forms of ownership for a magistracy, which primarily elevated the dignity of the titular holder rather than shareholders. Because financial offices generated large pecuniary yields and relatively insignificant returns from dignity, they could be owned and traded like stakes in a commercial enterprise.

Compared to the *receveurs généraux*, local *receveurs des tailles* in Normandy's *élections* earned more modest monetary yields of 5–9%, generally surpassing estimated dignity residuals of 2–6%.<sup>189</sup> Emoluments constituted most of the income.<sup>190</sup> At 12,000–40,000 *livres*, office values were comparable to those of lieutenant-general and affordable for middling bourgeois.<sup>191</sup> Each *élection* also had a *président*, a lieutenant, and *élus*.<sup>192</sup> These judicial and administrative officers collected fees linked to the activity of their post, which involved accounting, criminal proceedings, and tax assessment.<sup>193</sup> In the *élection* of Caudebac, their office values ranged from 6,000–10,000 *livres*, far lower than the value of a local receivership, which was 35,000 *livres*.<sup>194</sup> Yet, the *Enquête* lists the *présidents*, lieutenant, and *élus* before the *receveurs des tailles*, as justice takes precedence over finance.<sup>195</sup> Intuitively, dignity comprised more of the return on these petty judicial offices, considered higher in dignity yet lower in value.

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<sup>188</sup> Dessert, *Argent*, 49.

<sup>189</sup> See Appendix Table 11.

<sup>190</sup> See Appendix Table 11.

<sup>191</sup> See Appendix Tables 8 and 11.

<sup>192</sup> BnF 500 Colbert 260, folios 190–196.

<sup>193</sup> Voysin, *Mémoire*, 130.

<sup>194</sup> BnF 500 Colbert 260, folios 191–192.

<sup>195</sup> See Appendix Figure 5.

For the *receveurs*, the estimated pecuniary return should be interpreted as a lower bound, given potential arbitrage profits.<sup>196</sup> A local *receveur* handled a yearly average of 45,000–135,000 *livres* in gross tax revenues, while a *receveur général* managed 760,758 *livres* on average.<sup>197</sup> With such funds, these creditworthy officers could borrow at favourable rates from local elites while making advance payments to the crown at higher rates.<sup>198</sup> A 1% difference in interest rates might generate hundreds or thousands of *livres* in arbitrage profits. Nonetheless, even at lower-bound estimates, the model demonstrates the significance of pecuniary returns on receiverships of royal revenues, characterising such offices as closer to financial investments.

A similar pattern existed in the *maîtrise des eaux et des forêts* for Rouen. The *receveur particulier des bois*, an intermediate office valued at 10,000 *livres*, earned up to a 12.084% return from emoluments, in addition to a 5.81% return from *gages*.<sup>199</sup> The model estimates yearly gross woodland revenues from Voysin's reports on forests and derives emoluments from the office's standard rate of 3 *deniers* per *livre*.<sup>200</sup> Even if one deducted half the return from emoluments due to mismanagement of royal forests, the pecuniary return on this particular receivership of woodland revenues would exceed 10%.

High-value financial offices offered privileged positions in the public credit system, which, like wider society, followed an order of precedence. At the top was the royal council of finance and its immediate circle of financiers. The 1661 *chambre de justice* had removed the

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<sup>196</sup> Rowlands, *Financial decline*, 60.

<sup>197</sup> See Appendix Table 10.

<sup>198</sup> Rowlands, *Financial decline*, 59.

<sup>199</sup> See Appendix Tables 13 and 14.

<sup>200</sup> Voysin, *Mémoire*, 116–117; *Déclaration du roy, qui unit les corps et titres des offices de receveurs particuliers des eaux et forests qui restent à vendre de ceux créés par édit... de décembre 1701, aux offices de receveurs généraux anciens, alternatifs et demytriennaux des domaines et bois des provinces et généralitez qui y sont dénommées* (Paris, 1703), 2.

chief financiers of the Mazarin clan, whom Colbert replaced with his own financier lobby.<sup>201</sup> Relationships with those who decided financial policy limited default risk, enabling moral hazard. As a financier, Colbert would buy up depreciated *rentes* for Mazarin and redeem them at the treasury for the original high price.<sup>202</sup> Surrounding the leading financial clan were around 534 individuals whom Daniel Dessert identifies as “principal financiers”.<sup>203</sup> 85.4% of them were officers and 79% were nobles or recently ennobled.<sup>204</sup> The 229 identified individuals condemned by the *chambre de justice* included 31 *receveurs généraux des finances*, 11 *trésoriers de France*, 10 *élus* and *receveurs des tailles*, and 162 other officers.<sup>205</sup> These were primary receiverships, important secondary receiverships, and high-ranking offices.<sup>206</sup> 19 of the condemned were nobles, and 145 others held the office of royal secretary, the proverbial *savonnette à vilain*, which ennobled its holder in a generation of service.<sup>207</sup> As Gary B. McCollim says, these men who served the crown by providing money represented another kind of nobility, separate from the *noblesse d’épée* and *noblesse de robe*.<sup>208</sup>

The principal financiers might be considered a *noblesse de l’argent*, ranked below the warriors and magistrates but above the merchants.<sup>209</sup> They wore large white collars and buttoned tunics but without the magistrates’ robes, as shown by a portrait of Pierre Monnerot, a great financier of Mazarin.<sup>210</sup> With fortunes of perhaps 400,000–1,000,000 *livres*, the *noblesse de*

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<sup>201</sup> Daniel Dessert, ‘Finances et société au XVIIe siècle: à propos de la chambre de justice de 1661’, *Annales. Economies, sociétés, civilisations* 29:4 (1974), 868–869.

<sup>202</sup> Moote, *Revolt of the judges*, 375.

<sup>203</sup> Dessert, *Argent*, 86–87.

<sup>204</sup> Dessert, *Argent*, 87.

<sup>205</sup> Dessert, ‘Finances’, 852.

<sup>206</sup> See Appendix Table 16.

<sup>207</sup> Dessert, ‘Finances’, 852, 856.

<sup>208</sup> McCollim, *Assault on privilege*, 44.

<sup>209</sup> McCollim, *Assault on privilege*, 44.

<sup>210</sup> McCollim, *Assault on privilege*, 47.

*l'argent* performed an indispensable service to the crown as financial intermediaries.<sup>211</sup>

Borrowing funds from the great aristocracy and robe nobility, the financiers heavily invested their fortunes in *rentes*, *billets*, shares in offices, shares in tax farms, and *traités*.<sup>212</sup> Under the cardinal-ministers, the crown sold the rights to *aides*, *octrois*, or other taxes at heavy discount to *traitants*; the *traitants* and their financial backers provided an immediate advance payment, delivered the rest of the taxes over a few years, took a proportional allowance, and deducted any expenses from the receipts.<sup>213</sup> The effective cost of credit for the crown was about 23–33% of the gross total.<sup>214</sup> A successful contract offered an annual return of tens of thousands of *livres*.<sup>215</sup> Colbert's father, Nicolas Camus, who possessed just 88,698 *livres* worth of property in Paris, owned the right to the *aides engagées* for the *élection* of Joigny, valued at 172,861 *livres*, and various *rentes* secured on the *aides*, the *gabelles*, the *tailles*, and the *cinq grosses fermes*, valued at 950,611 *livres*.<sup>216</sup> Significantly, Nicolas purchased many *rentes* at depreciated prices, perhaps reflecting confidence in his powerful financial backers.<sup>217</sup> His principal providers of funds consisted of illustrious personages such as the *conseiller d'état* Omer Talon and the *maréchal* and the *maréchale* de Gramont, the latter the first cousin of Richelieu.<sup>218</sup> The intermediation of the *noblesse de l'argent* kept the great aristocracy and robe nobility actively involved in public finances.

French public finances were characterised by compartmentalised revenues, short-term borrowing, and upfront instalments of money. The crown relied on hundreds of financiers,

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<sup>211</sup> McCollim, *Assault on privilege*, 47–48.

<sup>212</sup> Dessert, 'Finances', 858, 868.

<sup>213</sup> Rowlands, *Financial decline*, 83.

<sup>214</sup> Bonney, *The king's debts*, 315–316.

<sup>215</sup> Dessert, 'Finances', 860.

<sup>216</sup> Bourgeon, *Les Colbert*, 252–253.

<sup>217</sup> Bourgeon, *Les Colbert*, 252.

<sup>218</sup> Bourgeon, *Les Colbert*, 254.

embedded in the fiscal administration by their offices, to provide advances and deposits with short-term credit. These deposits serviced different categories of *rentes* secured on regular revenue streams like the *gabelles* and *tailles*. This fragmented system of finances mitigated the risk of sovereign discretion. When the sovereign power lacked credible constraints on its financial behaviour and could alter contracts arbitrarily, creditors preferred to diversify exposure to risk across several claims on separate revenue streams rather than committing capital to a single institution.<sup>219</sup> Lending short-term to numerous financiers was therefore safer than placing long-term deposits in a central bank. Many proposals to establish such a bank failed, as fiscal conservatism prevailed in ministerial circles and the public was reluctant to entrust funds to an institution dependent on the government.<sup>220</sup> Hence, public finances were fragmented, like a mosaic: individual financiers might become bankrupt, and some *rentes* might go unpaid, but the broader system remained afloat.

Because the system depended upon financiers raising many short-term loans, the government had to preserve their creditworthiness and permit a degree of deficient accounting and profiteering.<sup>221</sup> In Richelieu's words,<sup>222</sup> the financiers composed "a group apart, prejudicial to the best interests of the state but nevertheless indispensable." Their credit financed canals, roads, armies, fortifications, ships, and colonial enterprises. The system functioned ably to some extent. After Colbert's reforms, France could comfortably sustain about 200–300 million *livres* of debt, excluding venal offices.<sup>223</sup> Yet, the risk of selective default and the moral hazard of privileging

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<sup>219</sup> On the subject of institutional constraints on sovereign behaviour, see: Douglass C. North and Barry R. Weingast, 'Constitutions and commitment: The evolution of institutions governing public choice in seventeenth-century England', *The Journal of Economic History* 49:4 (1988), 807–808, 828–830.

<sup>220</sup> Bonney, *The king's debts*, 280–281.

<sup>221</sup> Rowlands, *Financial decline*, 8.

<sup>222</sup> Armand Jean du Plessis de Richelieu, *The political testament of Cardinal Richelieu* (Madison, 1961), 29.

<sup>223</sup> Rowlands, *Financial decline*, 236.

some creditors above others kept borrowing costs elevated. According to the financiers, interest rates would have been as low as those in the Netherlands but for the fear that the crown would default.<sup>224</sup> During the Fronde, Parisian *parlementaires* demanded institutional checks on royal financial administration to guarantee the regular servicing of *rentes*.<sup>225</sup> Had this programme prevailed, credible constraints on the sovereign might have facilitated the growth of a more efficient and centralised system of public banking. Instead, sovereign discretion kept the financial public narrow and credit markets weak. Without credible constraints, the fragmentation of finances constituted a second-best equilibrium, spreading default risk across multiple intermediaries and debt instruments and allowing the government to borrow through financier “sub-publics”.

In this chapter, we have seen that financial offices behaved like shares in a business enterprise with high pecuniary returns. Comprising a *noblesse de l'argent*, the state's principal financiers possessed primary receiverships, secondary receiverships, and other offices of rank, serving as financial intermediaries between the high aristocracy and the crown. Venal offices held together this network of privileged creditors, who owned considerable capitalised claims on public revenues. Under sovereign discretion, public finances spread risk across hundreds of financiers borrowing short-term credit to make upfront deposits that serviced separate *rentes*. As Richard Bonney states, the consolidated debt was necessarily inefficient, but its very existence encumbered structural reform towards developing a sound, firmly based financial system.<sup>226</sup> This constituted a kind of debt overhang problem, obstructing administrative fiscal reforms that might

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<sup>224</sup> Bonney, *The king's debts*, 274.

<sup>225</sup> Bonney, *The king's debts*, 281.

<sup>226</sup> Bonney, *The king's debts*, 282.

improve efficiency and public credit. Colbert's programme to abolish venality failed to overcome these institutional constraints.

## Conclusion

Colbert's *Avis sur l'annuel* reveals his perspective regarding the venality of offices. His central concern was that offices were macroeconomically inefficient, since they removed capital from the wider economy.<sup>227</sup> With high returns from dignity, judicial offices were essentially illiquid assets, only accessible to a certain milieu and difficult to exchange at full value. Shares in lucrative financial offices were somewhat more liquid, but these did not circulate broadly. In this respect, Véron de Forbonnais was probably correct in his assessment that the 420 million *livres* of capital in judicial and financial offices comprised two-thirds of France's money stock, and withdrawing even half this amount would have reduced interest rates by a third.<sup>228</sup>

One method towards eliminating venality, Colbert posits, is abolishing the *annuel*.<sup>229</sup> Office values would drop considerably to pre-1604 levels, as the required return would rise to cover the risk of losing all the office's capital under the Forty Days Rule. This would effectively reprice offices at far lower values and make it easier to reimburse officers, though the crown would lose the paulette's revenue. Additionally, Colbert notes that over 20,000 officers have borrowed part of the price of their offices, and all the *receveurs généraux des finances* and the *receveurs des tailles* have their entire fortunes invested in their offices.<sup>230</sup> Abolishing the paulette would financially ruin 20,000 officer families and another 20,000 creditor families.<sup>231</sup> This would generate a short-term credit crunch, temporarily raising the crown's borrowing rates. Colbert's

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<sup>227</sup> Colbert, *Lettres*, 6.248.

<sup>228</sup> Doyle, 'Colbert', 475.

<sup>229</sup> Colbert, *Lettres*, 6.248.

<sup>230</sup> Colbert, *Lettres*, 6.247–249.

<sup>231</sup> Colbert, *Lettres*, 6.248.

close financiers, including friends and relatives from Reims, would undoubtedly suffer too.<sup>232</sup> Moreover, this almost ruthless policy would undermine royal authority and even raise the possibility of internal revolution.<sup>233</sup> Only a generation ago, the magistrates revolted and began the Fronde, after the crown had withheld payments of *gages* and the renewal of the *paulette* to force new fiscal measures through the *Parlement* of Paris.<sup>234</sup> Although the Mazarinists prevailed, a “miniature Fronde” endured from 1652–1661, involving strikes or threatened strikes by magistrates, lawyers, merchants, *rentiers*, and peasants.<sup>235</sup> Whenever Mazarin’s ministers attempted to eliminate an obnoxious restriction on royal taxation or groped toward comprehensive solutions, they encountered widespread opposition, resulting in institutional inertia.<sup>236</sup> Royal tampering with the *paulette* had implicit political dangers, which Colbert understood.

One might conceptualise Colbert’s predicament as a model, resembling Myers’ debt overhang model.<sup>237</sup> The crown pursues a reform policy only if the change in value  $V_1 - V_0$  outweighs the investment cost  $I$  of administering the reform, the cost of financial distress  $D$ , and the cost of political risk  $P$ . For a heavily indebted government, the immediate administrative cost of reform may require repricing or eliminating some claims on royal debt. Financial distress covers increased borrowing costs from a contraction in credit; these costs may expand considerably during periods of high borrowing, like wartime. Privileged creditors—the great aristocracy, the robe nobility, and the financiers—are willing to accept reform if their expected

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<sup>232</sup> On Colbert’s financier clan, see: Dessert, ‘Finances’, 868–869.

<sup>233</sup> Colbert, *Lettres*, 6.248–249.

<sup>234</sup> Bonney, *The king’s debts*, 202.

<sup>235</sup> Moote, *Revolt of the judges*, 357.

<sup>236</sup> Moote, *Revolt of the judges*, 357.

<sup>237</sup> On Myers’ corporate debt overhang model, see: Stewart C. Myers, ‘Determinants of corporate borrowing’, *Journal of Financial Economics* 5:2 (1977), 148–154.

share  $s$  of the value added by reform outweighs the reduction  $\lambda$  in value of their existing capitalised claims on public revenues and authority. These claims  $C$  include offices, *rentes*, *billets*, tax farms, and rights from *traités*. Under sovereign discretion, creditors may doubt the crown's commitment to compensation, reducing  $s$ . If privileged creditors are unwilling to accept reform, they can raise the political cost by refusing to register legislation, remonstrating, striking, intriguing, tolerating or encouraging local revolts, and finally, launching a major insurrection like the Fronde. The crown abandons the reform if the combined administrative, political, and financial costs exceed the value it brings.

For a reform to be sustained:

$$V_1 - V_0 \geq I + D + P$$

$$s(V_1 - V_0) \geq \lambda C$$

This model has broad applicability and reflects that reform is not necessarily impossible, only more challenging to sustain under the institution of venality. When offices are property, magistrates and financiers become embedded in the state and cannot be removed unless reimbursed. Furthermore, the financiers borrowed from the aristocracy, so any loss of value in their extensive capitalised claims would extend to their aristocratic backers. This explains why the *chambre de justice* conducts only a partial default and burns Mazarin's accounts to avoid attacking powerful personages.<sup>238</sup> Eliminating or repricing the claims of privileged creditors

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<sup>238</sup> Dessert, 'Finances', 860.

bears political consequences. In regards to abolishing the paulette, Colbert identifies the political risks and financial distress costs of cutting office prices. The reform might allow for improved tax collection and lower interest rates in the long run, but the undermining of royal authority, the prospect of insurrection, and the immediate credit collapse were sufficient to moderate Colbert's ambitions.

Informed by the *Enquête*, Colbert ultimately pursued policies that strengthened venality. He revised *annuel* payments upwards and established price ceilings slightly below the *prix courants*.<sup>239</sup> This price fixing gave the crown greater control over venality. After 1669, the seller of an office had to place it with the *parties casuelles*, and the buyer would deposit its transaction price with the *trésorier des parties casuelles*.<sup>240</sup> The crown would choose the office's successor from a queue of candidates who had deposited money.<sup>241</sup> When demand exceeded supply, queues for offices could take several years, during which the crown held the deposits as interest-free loans while controlling appointments.<sup>242</sup> Ordered to fund military preparations against the Dutch, Colbert sold new offices, venalised the wigmaker trade in 1673, and began the custom of requiring purchases of *augmentations de gages* before the renewal of the paulette in 1674.<sup>243</sup> An officer could theoretically refuse the *augmentation*, but this would expose his office to the Forty Days Rule and diminish its value far more than the cost of paying fourteen times its annual paulette at the rate of *denier* 14.<sup>244</sup> The precedent of *augmentations de gages* continued every nine years, rising from *denier* 14 to *denier* 18 in 1683.<sup>245</sup> Although the price ceilings and

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<sup>239</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 211–212.

<sup>240</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 214–215.

<sup>241</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 214–215.

<sup>242</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 214–215.

<sup>243</sup> Doyle, 'Colbert', 478–479.

<sup>244</sup> Hurt, *Louis XIV and the parlements*, 69.

<sup>245</sup> Hurt, *Louis XIV and the parlements*, 69.

*augmentations de gages* squeezed officers for credit, these policies largely preserved officers' capitalised claims and increased their *gages* so that offices retained at least a 5.556% return. By augmenting *gages*, the crown raised 200 million *livres* of long-term debt from its officers after 1689, supporting Louis XIV's final two, highly demanding wars.<sup>246</sup> Ironically, by enhancing venality's value to the crown, Colbert became venality's greatest guardian, making its abolition even more difficult.<sup>247</sup>

This thesis has studied venality through the lens of the *Enquête*, focusing on Normandy given its documentation; future research might extend the methodology used here to Paris, other *généralités*, and perhaps the colonies. The model here shows that the offices of magistrates primarily functioned as sources of dignity, whereas the offices of financiers behaved more like financial securities that generated substantial pecuniary returns. As a system, venality embedded a political and financial elite within society's upper orders—the *noblesse de robe* and *noblesse de l'argent*. The political prerogatives of the former and the credit of the latter restrained Colbert's efforts to abolish venality, which would likely have been politically and financially impossible in the decades between the Fronde and the Dutch War. As Dessert observes, the monarchy in its final decades recognised the necessity of reforms but faced systematic elite opposition headed by the *parlementaires*.<sup>248</sup> Eugene White demonstrates that gradual administrative tax reforms could have feasibly improved royal finances had the venal financial aristocracy not retaken control of fiscal administration after 1781.<sup>249</sup> In this regard, a future paper might explore whether the privileged creditor overhang model helps explain the failure of eighteenth-century reform

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<sup>246</sup> Rowlands, *Financial decline*, 87.

<sup>247</sup> Blanquie, *Une enquête*, 225.

<sup>248</sup> Dessert, 'Finances', 870–871.

<sup>249</sup> Eugene Nelson White, 'Was there a solution to the ancien régime's financial dilemma?', *The Journal of Economic History* 49:3 (1989), 546, 568.

programmes, ranging from John Law's experiment to the ministries of Maupeou and Terray. If eliminating venality was indeed necessary to sustain structural reform of fiscal administration and public finances, the question remains whether such a transformation could have occurred without revolution.

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**Appendix Table 1. Distribution of aggregate capitalised value across office categories in the *Parlement* of Rouen.<sup>250</sup>**

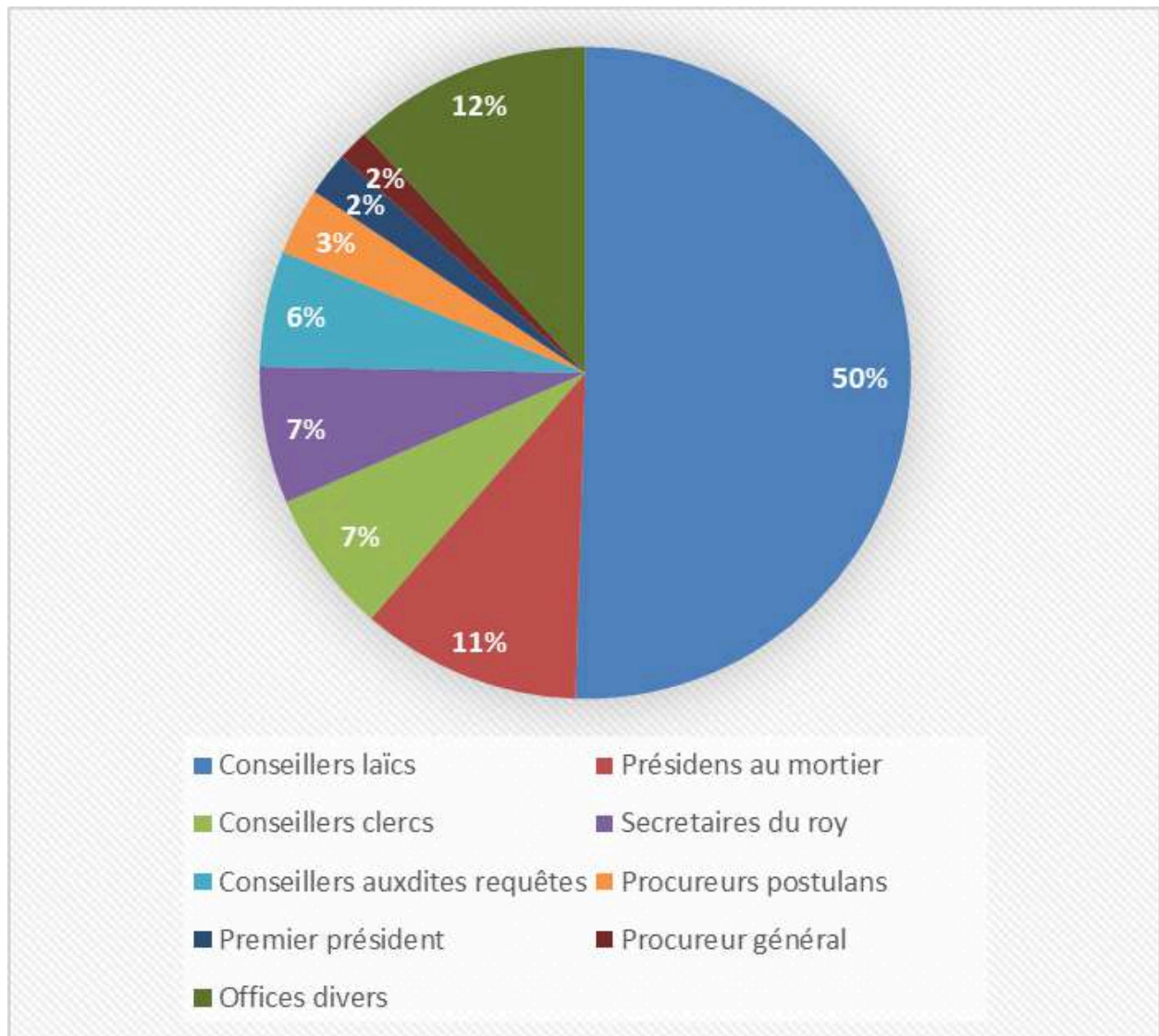
a)

| Office category                      | Aggregate value ( <i>livres</i> ) | Proportion of total company capitalisation |
|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <i>Conseillers laïcs</i>             | 5,808,000                         | 0.505                                      |
| <i>Présidens au mortier</i>          | 1,260,000                         | 0.109                                      |
| <i>Conseillers clerics</i>           | 816,000                           | 0.071                                      |
| <i>Secrétaires du roy</i>            | 782,000                           | 0.068                                      |
| <i>Conseillers auxdites requêtes</i> | 660,000                           | 0.057                                      |
| <i>Procureurs postulans</i>          | 384,000                           | 0.033                                      |
| <i>Premier président</i>             | 250,000                           | 0.022                                      |
| <i>Procureur général</i>             | 180,000                           | 0.016                                      |
| <i>Offices divers</i> <sup>251</sup> | 1,367,000                         | 0.119                                      |

<sup>250</sup> The figures for aggregate value come directly from the *Enquête*. The figures for percentages come from calculations in Excel. The table accounts for all venal offices in the *Parlement* of Rouen, including those of the *greffier domaniaux* and of the *chancellerie près le parlement*; BnF 500 Colbert 260, folio 181.

<sup>251</sup> To avoid clutter, this category groups together all office categories with a 1% proportion of total aggregate value or less.

b)



**Appendix Table 2. Estimated composition of the annual equilibrium return on a *conseiller laïc* office in the *Grand Chambre* of the *Parlement* of Rouen in 1665.**<sup>252</sup>

a)

|                                    | Return (%) | Value ( <i>livres</i> ) | Proportion of required return |
|------------------------------------|------------|-------------------------|-------------------------------|
| <b><i>Gages</i></b> <sup>253</sup> | 0.256      | 225                     | 0.043                         |
| <b>Emoluments</b>                  | 0.682      | 600                     | 0.115                         |
| <b>Dignity</b>                     | 4.996      | 4396.889                | 0.842                         |

b)

| Office name                     | Pecuniary return (%) <sup>254</sup> | <i>Annuel</i> rate (%) | Required return (%) <sup>255</sup> | <i>Prix courant</i> ( <i>livres</i> ) |
|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------|------------------------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| <b><i>Conseillers laïcs</i></b> | 0.938                               | 0.378                  | 5.933                              | 88,000                                |

<sup>252</sup> *Conseillers laïcs* received 225 *livres* of annualised *gages* but had to pay ~333.33 *livres* for the *annuel* each year. This would correspond to a 0.256% return from *gages* and a 0.378% *annuel* rate; adding *denier* 18 and 0.378% gives a 5.933% required return. According to Voysin, *conseillers* in the *Grand Chambre* received 600 *livres* of emoluments from the *Parlement*'s common fund in a normal year, while *conseillers* in the *Chambre des Enquêtes* received 100 *livres*. Sometimes, the court would grant a *conseiller* a commission to examine cases from outside the court. A *conseiller* on commission from the *Grand Chambre* would receive an additional 1,200–1,500 *livres*, and a *conseiller* on commission from the *Chambre des Enquêtes* would receive 400 *livres*. However, given the infrequency of commissions, the model does not treat commission compensation as part of a *conseiller*'s regular income. But even if the model were to factor in commissions, that would increase the pecuniary return by less than 2%. If a *conseiller* was instead assigned to the *Chambre des Enquêtes* and received 100 *livres* of emoluments per year instead of 600, that would reduce the pecuniary return to  $(225+100)/88,000 = 0.37\%$ ; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 83–84; BnF 500 Colbert 260, folio 181; Marion, *Dictionnaire*, 120.

<sup>253</sup> A further adjustment to the model concerns the payment of *gages*. The crown typically did not pay the full statutory *gages* each year. Usually, an officer would receive only three-quarters or two-quarters of their allotted *gages*, and lesser officers might receive one-quarter or no *gages* at all. Accordingly, the model annualises *gages* based on the number of quarters recorded in the *Enquête*. For example, *conseillers laïcs* had a full *gages* of 300 *livres*, but the crown paid only three-quarters of it each year. Hence, the officers received 225 *livres* of annualised *gages*; BnF 500 Colbert 260, folio 181.

<sup>254</sup> Pecuniary return is the sum of the return from *gages* and the return from emoluments. That is, it is the gross return before deduction from the *annuel* rate, which is the office's *annuel* payment divided by its *prix courant*.

<sup>255</sup> As explained in Chapter 2, the sum of the king's *denier* (~5.556%) and the *annuel* rate is used as the benchmark for required return.

**Appendix Table 3. Estimated composition of the annual equilibrium return on office in the *Parlement* of Rouen in 1665, holding the return from emoluments fixed at 0.682%.<sup>256</sup>**

| Office name                             | Return from <i>gages</i> (%) | Return from emoluments (%) | Return from dignity (%) | <i>Prix courant</i> (livres) |
|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------|----------------------------|-------------------------|------------------------------|
| <i>Premier président</i>                | 1.238                        | 0.682                      | 3.636                   | 250,000                      |
| <i>Présidens au mortier</i>             | 0.938                        | 0.682                      | 4.381                   | 180,000                      |
| <i>Conseillers clerks</i>               | 0.320                        | 1.25 <sup>257</sup>        | 4.448                   | 48,000                       |
| <i>Conseillers laïcs</i>                | 0.256                        | 0.682                      | 4.996                   | 88,000                       |
| <i>Avocats généraux</i>                 | 0.799                        | 0.682                      | 4.815                   | 60,000                       |
| <i>Procureur général</i>                | 0.373                        | 0.682                      | 4.501                   | 180,000                      |
| <i>Substituts</i>                       | 2.363                        | 0.682                      | 2.953                   | 12,000                       |
| <i>Notaires secrétaires</i>             | 1.365                        | 0.682                      | 3.949                   | 15,000                       |
| <i>Premier huissier</i>                 | 1.288                        | 0.682                      | 5.436                   | 12,000                       |
| <i>Autres huissiers</i>                 | 0.742                        | 0.682                      | 5.232                   | 6,000                        |
| <i>Président aux requêtes du palais</i> | 0.500                        | 0.682                      | 4.966                   | 75,000                       |
| <i>Conseillers auxdites requêtes</i>    | 0.409                        | 0.682                      | 5.01                    | 55,000                       |
| <i>Huissiers desdites requêtes</i>      | 0.350                        | 0.682                      | 5.404                   | 5,000                        |

<sup>256</sup> The derivation of these rates of return follow the same methodology as before. First, each office's *annuel* rate is added to the king's *denier* at ~5.556%. This gives the required return. The return from *gages* is calculated based on data from the *Enquête*. Voysin's figures gives 0.682% as the return from emoluments for *conseillers laïcs*. In the absence of emolument data, 0.682% is used as a baseline for the return from emoluments for the other offices. Dignity is attributable to the residual after subtracting the pecuniary return from the required return. Evidence suggests that minor offices received a greater return from emoluments, so the table likely overestimates the return from dignity for lower-tier offices. Their actual return from dignity might be closer to 3–5%, consistent with offices of higher rank; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 83–84; BnF 500 Colbert 260, folio 181.

<sup>257</sup> Given that *conseillers* in the *Grand Chambre* received 600 *livres* in emoluments, the return from emoluments for *conseillers clerks* (clerical councillors) is adjusted accordingly to reflect this; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 83–84; BnF 500 Colbert 260, folio 181.

|                                                               |       |       |       |        |
|---------------------------------------------------------------|-------|-------|-------|--------|
| <i>Receveurs-payeurs des gages dudit parlement</i>            | 1.50  | 0.682 | 4.704 | 20,000 |
| <i>Controleurs desdits payeurs</i>                            | 1.125 | 0.682 | 5.079 | 10,000 |
| <i>Receveur des amendes</i>                                   | 0.145 | 0.682 | 5.469 | 15,000 |
| <i>Controleur desdites amendes</i>                            | 1.358 | 0.682 | 4.615 | 3,000  |
| <i>Receveur des consignations au parlement et juridiction</i> | 1.776 | 0.682 | 3.097 | 70,000 |
| <i>Procureurs postulans</i>                                   | 0     | 0.682 | 5.524 | 4,000  |
| <i>Concierger des prisons du palais</i>                       | 0     | 0.682 | 6.774 | 7,000  |

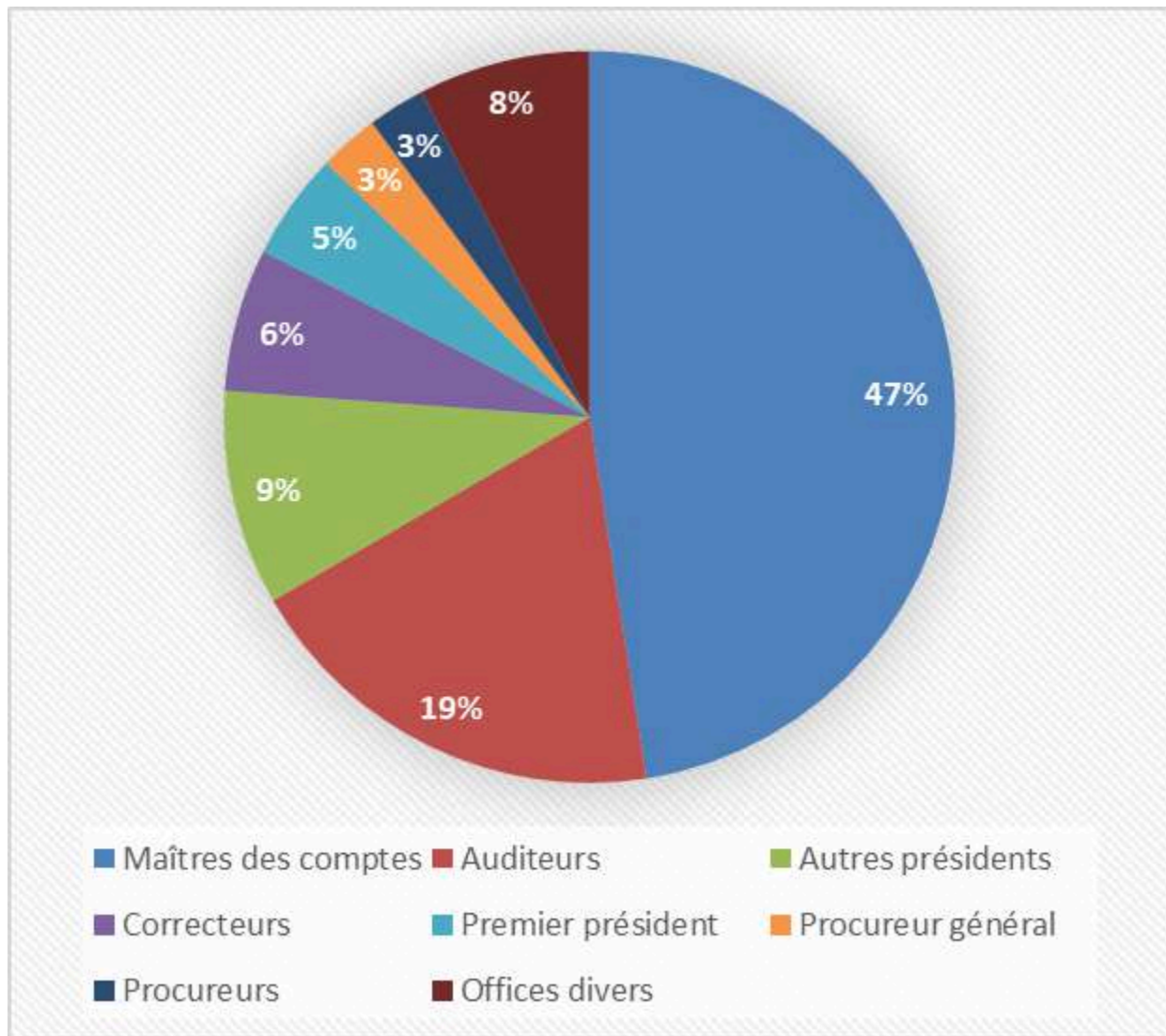
**Appendix Table 4. Distribution of aggregate capitalised value across office categories from Rouen's *chambre des comptes* in 1665.<sup>258</sup>**

a)

| Office category            | Aggregate value<br>(livres) | Proportion of total company capitalisation |
|----------------------------|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <i>Maîtres des comptes</i> | 1,800,000                   | 0.475                                      |
| <i>Auditeurs</i>           | 725,000                     | 0.191                                      |
| <i>Autres présidents</i>   | 360,000                     | 0.095                                      |
| <i>Correcteurs</i>         | 240,000                     | 0.063                                      |
| <i>Premier président</i>   | 180,000                     | 0.048                                      |
| <i>Procureur général</i>   | 100,000                     | 0.026                                      |
| <i>Procureurs</i>          | 96,000                      | 0.025                                      |
| <i>Offices divers</i>      | 288,000                     | 0.076                                      |

<sup>258</sup> BnF 500 Colbert 260, folio 182.

b)



**Appendix Table 5. Estimated composition of the annual equilibrium return on selected offices from Rouen's *chambre des comptes* in 1665.<sup>259</sup>**

a)

| Office name                | Return from <i>gages</i> (%) | Return from emoluments (%) | Return from dignity (%) | <i>Prix courant</i> (livres) |
|----------------------------|------------------------------|----------------------------|-------------------------|------------------------------|
| <i>Premier président</i>   | 1.119                        | 0.573                      | 4.419                   | 180,000                      |
| <i>Autres présidents</i>   | 1.023                        | 0.859                      | 4.341                   | 120,000                      |
| <i>Maîtres des comptes</i> | 1.273                        | 1.145                      | 3.730                   | 60,000                       |
| <i>Auditeurs</i>           | 1.848                        | 1.832                      | 2.584                   | 25,000                       |

b)

| Office name                | Pecuniary return (%) | <i>Annuel</i> rate (%) | Required return (%) |
|----------------------------|----------------------|------------------------|---------------------|
| <i>Premier président</i>   | 1.692                | 0.556                  | 6.111               |
| <i>Autres présidents</i>   | 1.881                | 0.667                  | 6.222               |
| <i>Maîtres des comptes</i> | 2.418                | 0.592                  | 6.147               |
| <i>Auditeurs</i>           | 3.680                | 0.708                  | 6.264               |

<sup>259</sup> The derivation of the return from emoluments relies on the accounts of Alexandre du Moucel, who earned an average of 687 *livres*/year in emoluments for his office of *maître ordinaire* in Rouen's *chambre de comptes* from 1604–1610. This provides a baseline for the emoluments of *maîtres* in 1665, and Voysin's ratios make it possible to estimate the emoluments of *auditeurs* and *présidents* from there. This table indicates it is plausible that *maîtres* and *auditeurs* received higher pecuniary returns than *conseiller laïcs* in the *parlement*. Their pecuniary returns were around 2.4% and 3.7% compared to the 0.94% of *conseiller laïcs*; BnF 500 Colbert 260, folio 182; Dewald, *Formation of a provincial nobility*, 335; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 84.

**Appendix Table 6. Estimated composition of the annual equilibrium return on the office of *conseiller* from Rouen's *bailliage* and *présidial* court in 1665.**<sup>260</sup>

a)

| Office name        | Emoluments<br>(livres) | Return from<br><i>gages</i> (%) | Return from<br>emoluments<br>(%) | Return<br>from dignity<br>(%) | <i>Prix courant</i><br>(livres) |
|--------------------|------------------------|---------------------------------|----------------------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| <i>Conseillers</i> | 375                    | 0.208                           | 3.125                            | 3.331                         | 12,000                          |
| <i>Conseillers</i> | 175                    | 0.208                           | 1.458                            | 4.997                         | 12,000                          |

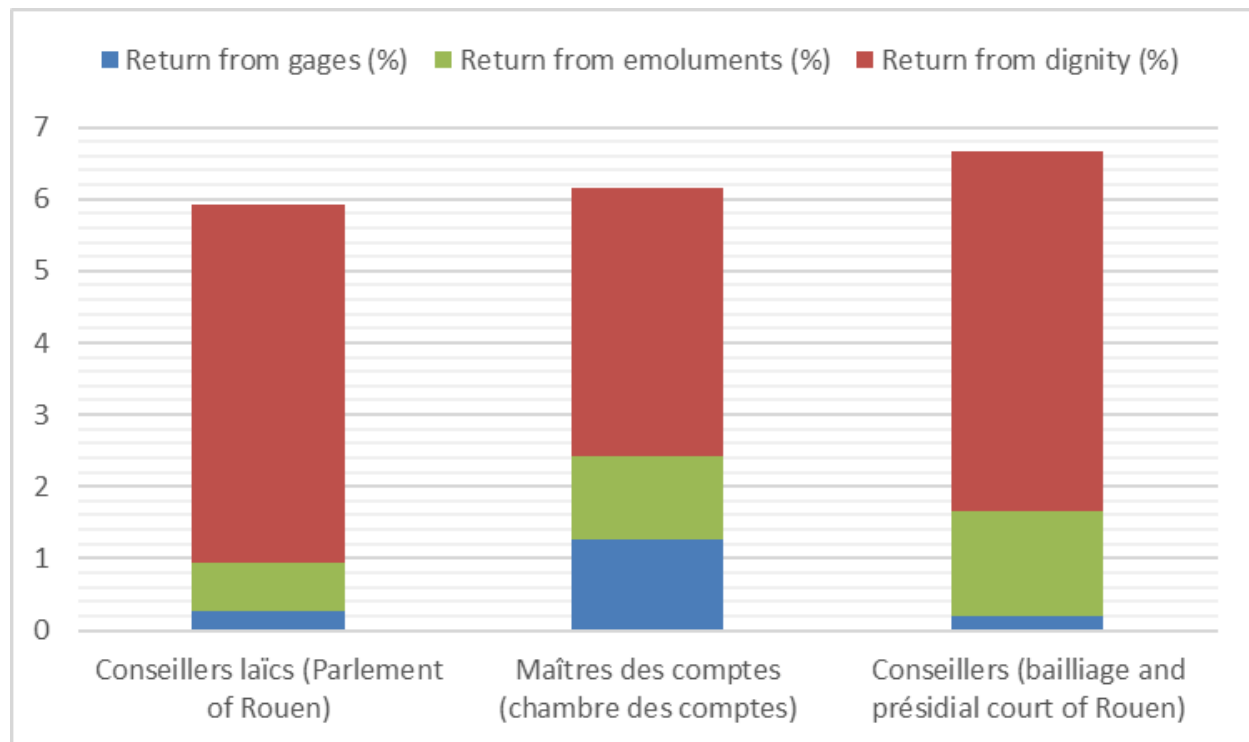
b)

| Office name        | Pecuniary return (%) | <i>Annuel rate</i> (%) | Required return (%) |
|--------------------|----------------------|------------------------|---------------------|
| <i>Conseillers</i> | 3.333                | 1.108                  | 6.664               |
| <i>Conseillers</i> | 1.667                | 1.108                  | 6.664               |

<sup>260</sup> Voysin states that the income of *conseillers* in the *bailliage* and *présidial* court of Rouen was between 200 and 400 *livres*. The *conseillers* earned *gages* of 25 *livres* per year, which implies they earned between 175 and 375 *livres* of emoluments. These tables approximate the composition of the equilibrium annual return on office, given the income range that Voysin provides. While the pecuniary return is relatively greater for *conseillers* in the *présidial* than in the *parlement*, the residual return attributable to dignity remains significant; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 91; BnF 500 Colbert 260 folio 183.

**Appendix Table 7. Estimated composition of equilibrium annual return on selected offices from Rouen.<sup>261</sup>**

**a)**



<sup>261</sup> This chart compares some findings from the model, examined in Appendix Tables 2, 5, and 6. The differences in the required return between offices are due to differences in the *annuel* rate. As the chart shows, the residual return attributable to dignity comprises the greater portion of the return on these judicial offices. However, this portion is larger for the *conseiller* in the *parlement* than the *conseiller* in the *présidial* or the *maître* in the *chambre des comptes*.

b)

| Office name                                                                | Return from<br><i>gages</i> (%) | Return from<br>emoluments (%) | Return from<br>dignity (%) | <i>Prix courant</i><br>(livres) |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|-------------------------------|----------------------------|---------------------------------|
| <i>Conseillers laïcs</i><br>(Parlement) <sup>262</sup>                     | 0.26                            | 0.682                         | 4.996                      | 88,000                          |
| <i>Maîtres des<br/>comptes</i><br>(chambre des<br>comptes) <sup>263</sup>  | 1.27                            | 1.145                         | 3.73                       | 60,000                          |
| <i>Conseillers</i><br>(bailliage and<br>présidial<br>court) <sup>264</sup> | 0.21                            | 1.458                         | 4.997                      | 12,000                          |

<sup>262</sup> *Conseillers* in the *Grand Chambre* received 225 *livres* of annualised *gages* and around 600 *livres* of emoluments; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 83–84; BnF 500 Colbert 260, folio 181; see Appendix 1.

<sup>263</sup> *Maîtres des comptes* received 763.5 *livres* of annualised *gages* and around 687 *livres* of emoluments; BnF 500 Colbert 260, folio 182; Dewald, *Formation of a provincial nobility*, 335; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 84; see Appendix Table 5.

<sup>264</sup> *Conseillers* from Rouen's *bailliage* and *présidial* court earned 25 *livres* of annualised *gages* and around 175–375 *livres* of emoluments. The table here uses the lower bound, 175 *livres*, as the baseline for emoluments; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 91; BnF 500 Colbert 260 folio 183; see Appendix Table 6.

**Appendix Table 8. Return from *gages* on ordinary magistracies in selected jurisdictions within Normandy in 1665.<sup>265</sup>**

**a) *Lieutenant général***

| <i>Bailliage</i> <sup>266</sup> | Return from <i>gages</i> (%) | <i>Prix courant</i> (livres) |
|---------------------------------|------------------------------|------------------------------|
| Pont-de-l'Arche                 | 0.104                        | 12,000                       |
| Pontaudemer                     | 0.02                         | 60,000                       |
| Pont-l'Évêque                   | 0                            | 36,000                       |
| Caudebec                        | 0.212                        | 25,000                       |
| Cany                            | 0.083                        | 15,000                       |
| Montivilliers                   | 0.229                        | 40,000                       |
| Neuchâtel                       | 0.104                        | 18,000                       |
| Lyons-la-Forêt                  | 0.324                        | 25,000                       |
| Andely                          | 0.891                        | 50,000                       |
| Vernon                          | 0.28                         | 10,000                       |

<sup>265</sup> The return from *gages* is calculated directly from the *Enquête* by dividing the annualised *gages* over the *prix courant*; BnF 500 Colbert 260, folios 183–190.

<sup>266</sup> A few *bailliages* contain differentiated offices of *lieutenants généraux*, such as a *lieutenant général civil* and a *lieutenant général criminel*. The *bailliage* of Gisors has a *lieutenant général ancien* and a *lieutenant général de nouvelle création*. To avoid confusion, this table lists only the *bailliages* with a single category of *lieutenant général*. In any case, the other offices of *lieutenant général civil* or *lieutenant général criminel* earn comparable returns from *gages* (0–1%), so their inclusion would not remarkably change the data; BnF 500 Colbert 260, folios 183–190.

b) *Vicomte*

| <i>Vicomté</i>                      | Return from <i>gages</i> (%) | <i>Prix courant</i> (livres) |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------|------------------------------|
| <b>Rouen</b>                        | 0.104                        | 60,000                       |
| <b>L'eau à Rouen</b> <sup>267</sup> | 0.208                        | 6,000                        |
| <b>Pont-de-l'Arche</b>              | 0                            | 12,000                       |
| <b>Pontaudemer</b>                  | 0.025                        | 50,000                       |
| <b>Pont-l'Évêque</b>                | 0                            | 30,000                       |
| <b>Caudebec</b>                     | 0.089                        | 14,000                       |
| <b>Montivilliers</b>                | 1.25                         | 30,000                       |
| <b>Arqués</b>                       | 0                            | 20,000                       |
| <b>Neuchâtel</b>                    | 0                            | 12,000                       |
| <b>Gisors</b>                       | 0.208                        | 12,000                       |
| <b>Lyons-la-Forêt</b>               | 0                            | 10,000                       |
| <b>Andely</b>                       | 0                            | 10,000                       |
| <b>Vernon</b>                       | 0                            | 15,000                       |
| <b>Évreux</b>                       | 0                            | 15,000                       |

<sup>267</sup> The *vicomté de l'Eaux à Rouen* was a unique jurisdiction that was subordinate to the *vicomté de Rouen*. It was not representative of *vicomtés* in the rest of the *généralité*, as indicated by its unusually low *prix courant*. In all other jurisdictions within Normandy, the administratively assessed value of an ordinary magistracy, such as *lieutenant général* or *vicomte*, never fell below 10,000 *livres*; BnF 500 Colbert 260, folios 183–190.

**Appendix Table 9. Salt delivered by the *greniers à sel* in Normandy in 1665, with prices in *livres* per *minot* and quantities in *minots*.<sup>268</sup>**

**a) *Greniers de vente volontaire***<sup>269</sup>

| <i>Greniers de vente volontaire</i>   | <i>Prix marchand</i> | <i>Prix de vente</i> <sup>270</sup> | <i>Quantité vendue</i> <sup>271</sup> |
|---------------------------------------|----------------------|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| <b>Rouen et chambre de la Bouille</b> | 4                    | 32.925                              | 6,096                                 |
| <b>Pont-de-l'Arche</b>                | 4.25                 | 33.363                              | 1,440                                 |
| <b>Louviers</b>                       | 4                    | 33.629                              | 2,400                                 |
| <b>Andely</b>                         | 4.5                  | 33.654                              | 768                                   |
| <b>Vernon</b>                         | 4.5                  | 33.625                              | 2,208                                 |
| <b>Évreux</b>                         | 4.5                  | 33.625                              | 4,800                                 |
| <b>Gisors</b>                         | 5                    | 34.15                               | 2,880                                 |
| <b>Gournay</b>                        | 5                    | 34.067                              | 1,920                                 |
| <b>Neufchâtel</b>                     | 4.5                  | 33.625                              | 2,160                                 |
| <b>Caudebac</b>                       | 4                    | 32.979                              | 2,880                                 |

<sup>268</sup> The table is reproduced from Voysin's memoranda. All prices are in *livres* per *minot* and all quantities are in *minots* per year; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 133–134.

<sup>269</sup> These were districts that were not subject to compulsory salt purchases under the *grand gabelle*; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 133–134.

<sup>270</sup> The egregiously high differences between the crown's monopoly price and the wholesale price help explain why the *gabelle* was so widely resented. For every *minot* of salt, buyers were paying upwards of a 700% premium or about 30 *livres* above the market price.

<sup>271</sup> Voysin's original memoranda expresses *quantités vendues* in *muids de Paris*. For convenience, they have been recalculated as *minots* here. He also notes that a few *greniers* used to sell greater quantities of salt before the war. For consistency, only the current figures for 1665 are used in this table; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 133–134.

**b) Greniers d'impôt<sup>272</sup>**

| <i>Greniers d'impôt</i>         | <i>Prix marchand</i> | <i>Prix de sel d'impôt</i> | <i>Prix de sel de vente volontaire</i> | <i>Quantité vendue par impôt</i> | <i>Quantité vendue par vente extraordinaire<sup>273</sup></i> |
|---------------------------------|----------------------|----------------------------|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Honfleur</b>                 | 4.75                 | 33.079                     | 33.829                                 | 966                              | 120                                                           |
| <b>Harfleur<sup>274</sup></b>   | 3.5                  | 33.742                     | 33.45                                  | 1417.5                           | 144                                                           |
| <b>Le Havre-de-Grâce</b>        | 3.5                  | 33.367                     | 33.367                                 | 462.75                           | 168                                                           |
| <b>Fécamp</b>                   | 4                    | 33.763                     | 33.15                                  | 1913.5                           | 144                                                           |
| <b>Saint-Valery (chambre)</b>   | 4.5                  | 34.292                     | 34.5                                   | 501.5                            | 96                                                            |
| <b>Dieppe</b>                   | 4.5                  | 33.158                     | 34                                     | 2617.5                           | 144                                                           |
| <b>Eu et chambre de Tréport</b> | 4.5                  | 33.979                     | 33.433                                 | 937                              | 312                                                           |
| <b>Pontaudemer</b>              | 4                    | 34.738                     | 33.5                                   | 684                              | 2184                                                          |

**Total net revenue of all above *greniers*: 1,179,192.919 livres**

<sup>272</sup> These were districts that were subject to compulsory salt purchases under the *grand gabelle*. Each parish was assigned an assessment of mandatory salt which they had to purchase from their local *grenier*. The salt storehouses in Normandy were of *petit impôt*, in that the assessments were set at a modest proportion of total household salt consumption. Taxpayers could choose to purchase more salt in addition to the imposed quantity. There were some inequalities of assessment. Voysin informed Colbert that Fécamp, Saint-Valery, and Honfleur were overburdened compared to Le Havre; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 133–134.

<sup>273</sup> Voysin sometimes gives an approximate range of figures (e.g. 2 or 3 *muids*) for the *quantité vendue par vente extraordinaire*. When this is the case, the table uses the average.

<sup>274</sup> This was a *grenier de franchise*, where certain privileged individuals could obtain their salt at the *prix marchand*, as could fishermen for the salting of fish; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 132, 134.

**Appendix Table 10. Aggregate tax assessments and allowances for the *élections* of Normandy in 1665 (*livres tournois*).<sup>275</sup>**

a)

| <i>Élection</i>            | Tax assessment <sup>276</sup> | 4 <i>deniers</i> per <i>livre</i> (1.667%) <sup>277</sup> |
|----------------------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Rouen</b>               | 224,739                       | 3,745.65                                                  |
| <b>Pont de l'Arche</b>     | 121,860                       | 2,031                                                     |
| <b>Pontaudemer</b>         | 260,531                       | 4,342.183                                                 |
| <b>Pont-l'Évêque</b>       | 148,128                       | 2,468.8                                                   |
| <b>Caudebac</b>            | 271,455                       | 4,524.25                                                  |
| <b>Montivilliers</b>       | 190,317                       | 3,171.95                                                  |
| <b>Arques</b>              | 285,181                       | 4,753.017                                                 |
| <b>Neuchâtel</b>           | 123,390                       | 2056.5                                                    |
| <b>Gisors et Ponthoise</b> | 171,648                       | 2,860.8                                                   |
| <b>Lyons-la-Forêt</b>      | 91,080                        | 1518                                                      |
| <b>Chaumont et Magny</b>   | 112,990                       | 1,883.167                                                 |
| <b>Andely</b>              | 129,436                       | 2,157.267                                                 |
| <b>Évreux</b>              | 151,518                       | 2525.3                                                    |

<sup>275</sup> Voysin's memoranda includes a table of all the parishes in the Rouen *généralité* and their tax assessments. This table records the sum of all the assessments in each *élection*; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 164–182.

<sup>276</sup> To find the average amount of funds each *receveur* handles per year, we would divide the values in this column by two, since there were two *receveurs des tailles* in each *élection*.

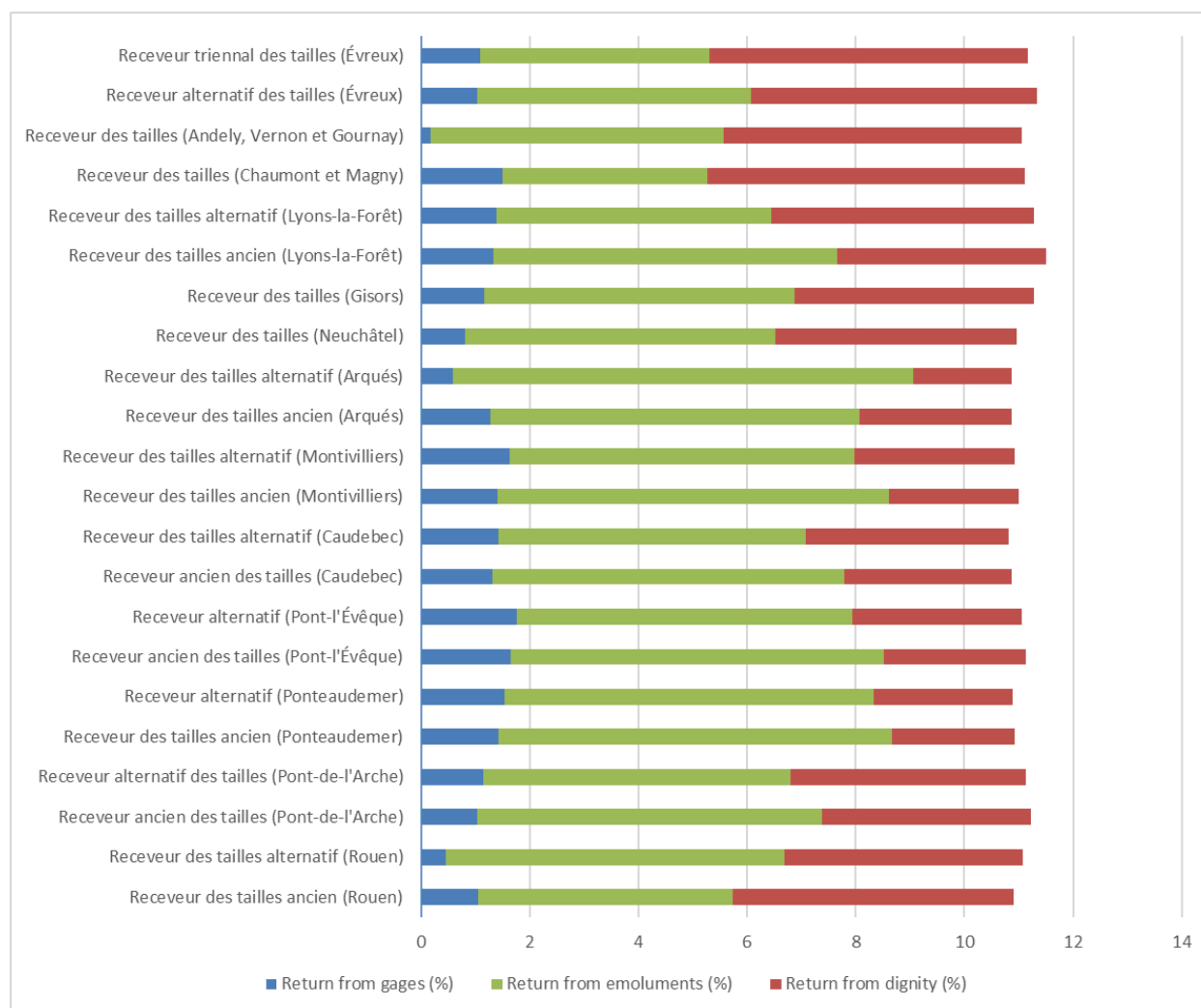
<sup>277</sup> The Declaration of 22 September 1662 assigned nine *deniers* per *livre* to the *receveurs généraux* and *particulier* of the *tailles*; of this nine *deniers*, the *receveurs généraux des finances* earned five *deniers* per *livre* and the local *receveurs* obtained the other four. In 1665, there were three *receveurs généraux des finances* in Normandy and two *receveurs des tailles* in each *élection*. By dividing the values in this column by two, one can approximate average yearly emoluments for a *receveur des tailles* exercising the office biennially; *Édit du roy, portant attribution aux receveurs généraux des finances*, 1–2.

**b)**

|                           | <b>Tax assessment</b> | <b>5 deniers per livre (2.083%)</b> |
|---------------------------|-----------------------|-------------------------------------|
| <b>Total for Normandy</b> | 2,282,273             | 47,547.35                           |

**Appendix Table 11. Estimated composition of equilibrium annual return on the office of *receveur des tailles* in the *élections* of Normandy in 1665.<sup>278</sup>**

a)



<sup>278</sup> For the required return, the model adds the *annuel* rate to a benchmark rate of 10.4%, which was the interest on certain royal loan contracts in 1661. The *Enquête* gives figures to calculate the return from *gages*, and emoluments are calculated from the legal allowance of four *deniers* per *livre* (~1.667%) on sums handled by the local *receveur des tailles*. Average yearly emoluments consist of this allowance divided by two, as each *receveur des tailles* exercised the office biennially. We divide yearly emoluments by the *prix courant* to derive the return from emoluments, then attribute the residual to dignity. This residual varies in size depending on what benchmark rate is adopted for the required return, though it provides some general idea of how important dignity was to these offices. The figures for *gages* and emoluments are more well-grounded in hard, verifiable data; BnF 500 Colbert 260, folios 190–194; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 164–182; Bonney, *The king's debts*, 318; see Appendix 10.

b)

| Office name and <i>élection</i>                              | Return from<br><i>gages</i> (%) | Return from<br>emoluments (%) | Return from<br>dignity (%) | <i>Prix<br/>courant<br/>(livres)</i> |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|-------------------------------|----------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| <i>Receveur des tailles ancien (Rouen)</i>                   | 1.057                           | 4.682                         | 5.161                      | 40,000                               |
| <i>Receveur des tailles alternatif (Rouen)</i>               | 0.455                           | 6.243                         | 4.369                      | 30,000                               |
| <i>Receveur ancien des tailles<br/>(Pont-de-l'Arche)</i>     | 1.034                           | 6.347                         | 3.850                      | 16,000                               |
| <i>Receveur alternatif des tailles<br/>(Pont-de-l'Arche)</i> | 1.151                           | 5.642                         | 4.346                      | 18,000                               |
| <i>Receveur des tailles ancien<br/>(Ponteaudemer)</i>        | 1.423                           | 7.237                         | 2.257                      | 30,000                               |
| <i>Receveur alternatif (Ponteaudemer)</i>                    | 1.541                           | 6.785                         | 2.558                      | 32000                                |
| <i>Receveur ancien des tailles<br/>(Pont-l'Évêque)</i>       | 1.653                           | 6.858                         | 2.628                      | 18,000                               |
| <i>Receveur alternatif (Pont-l'Évêque)</i>                   | 1.761                           | 6.172                         | 3.132                      | 20,000                               |
| <i>Receveur ancien des tailles (Caudebec)</i>                | 1.32                            | 6.463                         | 3.091                      | 35,000                               |
| <i>Receveur des tailles alternatif<br/>(Caudebec)</i>        | 1.431                           | 5.655                         | 3.728                      | 40,000                               |
| <i>Receveur des tailles ancien<br/>(Montivilliers)</i>       | 1.401                           | 7.209                         | 2.394                      | 22,000                               |
| <i>Receveur des tailles alternatif<br/>(Montivilliers)</i>   | 1.634                           | 6.344                         | 2.954                      | 25,000                               |
| <i>Receveur des tailles ancien (Arqués)</i>                  | 1.281                           | 6.790                         | 2.803                      | 35,000                               |
| <i>Receveur des tailles alternatif (Arqués)</i>              | 0.578                           | 8.488                         | 1.810                      | 28,000                               |
| <i>Receveur des tailles (Neuchâtel)</i>                      | 0.803                           | 5.713                         | 4.440                      | 18,000                               |
| <i>Receveur des tailles (Gisors)</i>                         | 1.163                           | 5.722                         | 4.403                      | 25,000                               |
| <i>Receveur des tailles ancien<br/>(Lyons-la-Forêt)</i>      | 1.329                           | 6.325                         | 3.854                      | 12,000                               |

|                                                         |       |       |       |        |
|---------------------------------------------------------|-------|-------|-------|--------|
| <i>Receveur des tailles alternatif (Lyons-la-Forêt)</i> | 1.387 | 5.060 | 4.840 | 15,000 |
| <i>Receveur des tailles (Chaumont et Magny)</i>         | 1.500 | 3.766 | 5.842 | 25,000 |
| <i>Receveur des tailles (Andely, Vernon et Gournay)</i> | 0.185 | 5.393 | 5.487 | 20,000 |
| <i>Receveur alternatif des tailles (Évreux)</i>         | 1.030 | 5.051 | 5.251 | 25,000 |
| <i>Receveur triennal des tailles (Évreux)</i>           | 1.098 | 4.209 | 5.870 | 30,000 |

c)

| Office name and <i>élection</i>                          | Pecuniary return (%) | Annual rate (%) | Required return (%) |
|----------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|-----------------|---------------------|
| <i>Receveur des tailles ancien (Rouen)</i>               | 5.739                | 0.500           | 10.900              |
| <i>Receveur des tailles alternatif (Rouen)</i>           | 6.698                | 0.667           | 11.067              |
| <i>Receveur ancien des tailles (Pont-de-l'Arche)</i>     | 7.381                | 0.831           | 11.231              |
| <i>Receveur alternatif des tailles (Pont-de-l'Arche)</i> | 6.793                | 0.739           | 11.139              |
| <i>Receveur des tailles ancien (Ponteaudemer)</i>        | 8.659                | 0.517           | 10.917              |
| <i>Receveur alternatif (Ponteaudemer)</i>                | 8.326                | 0.484           | 10.884              |
| <i>Receveur ancien des tailles (Pont-l'Évêque)</i>       | 8.511                | 0.739           | 11.139              |
| <i>Receveur alternatif (Pont-l'Évêque)</i>               | 7.933                | 0.665           | 11.065              |
| <i>Receveur ancien des tailles (Caudebec)</i>            | 7.783                | 0.474           | 10.874              |
| <i>Receveur des tailles alternatif (Caudebec)</i>        | 7.087                | 0.415           | 10.815              |
| <i>Receveur des tailles ancien (Montivilliers)</i>       | 8.610                | 0.605           | 11.005              |
| <i>Receveur des tailles alternatif (Montivilliers)</i>   | 7.978                | 0.532           | 10.932              |
| <i>Receveur des tailles ancien (Arqués)</i>              | 8.071                | 0.474           | 10.874              |
| <i>Receveur des tailles alternatif (Arqués)</i>          | 9.065                | 0.475           | 10.875              |
| <i>Receveur des tailles (Neuchâtel)</i>                  | 6.515                | 0.556           | 10.956              |

|                                                         |       |       |        |
|---------------------------------------------------------|-------|-------|--------|
| <i>Receveur des tailles (Gisors)</i>                    | 6.885 | 0.888 | 11.288 |
| <i>Receveur des tailles ancien (Lyons-la-Forêt)</i>     | 7.654 | 1.108 | 11.508 |
| <i>Receveur des tailles alternatif (Lyons-la-Forêt)</i> | 6.447 | 0.887 | 11.287 |
| <i>Receveur des tailles (Chaumont et Magny)</i>         | 5.266 | 0.708 | 11.108 |
| <i>Receveur des tailles (Andely, Vernon et Gournay)</i> | 5.578 | 0.665 | 11.065 |
| <i>Receveur alternatif des tailles (Évreux)</i>         | 6.081 | 0.932 | 11.332 |
| <i>Receveur triennal des tailles (Évreux)</i>           | 5.306 | 0.777 | 11.177 |

**Appendix Table 12. Estimated composition of pecuniary return on the office of *receveur général des finances* in Normandy's *bureau des finances* in 1665.<sup>279</sup>**

a)

| Office name                            | Return from<br><i>gages</i> (%) | Return from<br>emoluments (%) | <i>Prix courant</i><br>(livres) |
|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| <i>Receveurs généraux des finances</i> | 2.9                             | 15.849                        | 100,000                         |

b)

| Office name                            | Total sums<br>handled (livres) | Proportional<br>allowance (livres) <sup>280</sup> | Average yearly<br>emoluments (livres) |
|----------------------------------------|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| <i>Receveurs généraux des finances</i> | 2,282,273                      | 47,547.354                                        | 15,849.118                            |

c)

| Office name                            | Pecuniary return (%) | <i>Annuel</i> rate (%) |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------|------------------------|
| <i>Receveurs généraux des finances</i> | 18.749               | 1.066                  |

<sup>279</sup> BnF 500 Colbert 260, folios 182–183; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 164–182; see Appendix Table 10.

<sup>280</sup> Legally, the *receveurs généraux des finances* had a proportional allowance of 5 *deniers* per *livre*, fixed by the crown in 1662. Since there were three of them at this time in Normandy's *bureau des finances*, each one would exercise the office triennially and receive a yearly average of one-third of the allowance. This value should be interpreted as a lower-bound approximation of emoluments, since it does not account for the arbitrage profits these primary receivers could make by borrowing from local elites and making advance payments to the crown; *Édit du roy, portant attribution aux receveurs généraux des finances*, 1–2.

**Appendix Table 13. Estimated woodland revenues for the *maîtrise des eaux et des forêts de Rouen* in 1665.<sup>281</sup>**

a)

| Forest                                 | Rouvray | Rouvray | Rouvray  | La Londe | La Londe | Roumare | Longboël  |
|----------------------------------------|---------|---------|----------|----------|----------|---------|-----------|
| <i>Arpents</i>                         | 4015    | 2007.5  | 2007.5   | 1050     | 500      | 8413    | 1750      |
| <b>Price<br/>(livres)</b>              | 120     | 60      | 22.5     | 135      | 45       | 110     | 200       |
| <b>Cutting<br/>cycle<br/>(years)</b>   | 20      | 20      | 20       | 31       | 31       | 20      | 27.5      |
| <b>Annual<br/>revenue<br/>(livres)</b> | 24090   | 6022.5  | 2258.438 | 4572.581 | 725.806  | 46271.5 | 12727.272 |

b)

|                                                 | <b>Total annual revenue<br/>(livres)<sup>282</sup></b> | <b>3 deniers per livre (1.25%)<sup>283</sup></b> |
|-------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Maîtrise des eaux et des forêts de Rouen</i> | 96,668.097                                             | 1,208.351                                        |

<sup>281</sup> This table uses figures provided by Voysin to approximate the gross woodland revenues accruing to the *maîtrise des eaux et des forêts de Rouen*. When Voysin provides a range of values, the table uses the mean value. Some forests like Rouvray appear multiple times in the table, because Voysin distinguishes between different sections of the forest. For example, one quarter of Rouvray has lower quality soil, so the trees there are sold at a lower price. Voysin, *Mémoire*, 116–117.

<sup>282</sup> This should be interpreted as an upper-bound estimate if the royal forests were being managed optimally to maximise revenue. Voysin's description of some degraded royal forests suggests there was some mismanagement; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 116–117.

<sup>283</sup> The standard rate for *receveur particulier des bois* appears to have been 3 deniers per livre, as indicated by a 1703 edict. This allows for the approximation of the average yearly emoluments for the *receveur particulier des bois* in Rouen; *Déclaration du roy, qui unit les corps et titres des offices de receveurs particuliers des eaux et forests*, 2.

**Appendix Table 14. Estimated composition of annual pecuniary return on the office of *receveur particulier des bois du baillage de Rouen* in 1665.<sup>284</sup>**

| Office name                                                           | Return from<br><i>gages</i> (%) | Return from<br>emoluments (%) | <i>Annuel</i> rate<br>(%) | <i>Prix courant</i><br>(livres) |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------------|
| <i>Receveur<br/>particulier des<br/>bois du baillage<br/>de Rouen</i> | 5.81                            | 12.084                        | 0.53                      | 10,000                          |

<sup>284</sup> This table uses the estimate of gross woodland revenues from Appendix Table 13 to approximate the return from emoluments. What is most surprising about this office is the high return from *gages* and emoluments. Even if a third or a half of the return from emoluments is deducted due to the mismanagement of royal forests, the *receveur particulier des bois* in Rouen is making a pecuniary return exceeding 10%, with a minimal *annuel* rate of 0.53%. This is higher than the pecuniary return for *receveurs des tailles*; BnF 500 Colbert 260, folios 194–195; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 116–117.

**Appendix Table 15. Estimated return from emoluments on the office of *mesureurs de sel* in the *greniers à sel* of Normandy in 1665.**<sup>285</sup>

| <i>Grenier</i>                        | Return from emoluments (%) | <i>Annuel</i> rate (%) | <i>Prix courant</i> (livres) |
|---------------------------------------|----------------------------|------------------------|------------------------------|
| <i>Rouen et chambre de la Bouille</i> | 0.106                      | 1.5                    | 400                          |
| <i>Pont-de-l'Arche</i>                | 1.5                        | 3                      | 200                          |
| <i>Louviers</i>                       | 3.333                      | 3                      | 200                          |
| <i>Andely</i>                         | 1.067                      | 1.333                  | 300                          |
| <i>Évreux</i>                         | 3.333                      | 1.5                    | 400                          |
| <i>Gisors</i>                         | 1.333                      | 5.5                    | 600                          |
| <i>Gournay</i>                        | 4                          | 3                      | 200                          |
| <i>Neufchâtel</i>                     | 3                          | 2                      | 300                          |
| <i>Caudebac</i>                       | 2                          | 2                      | 300                          |
| <i>Honfleur</i>                       | 1.839                      | 1.5                    | 400                          |
| <i>Harfleur</i>                       | 1.084                      | 2.667                  | 300                          |
| <i>Le Havre-de-Grâce</i>              | 0.876                      | 13                     | 200                          |
| <i>Fécamp</i>                         | 2.858                      | 4                      | 200                          |
| <i>Eu et chambre de Tréport</i>       | 1.735                      | 3.667                  | 300                          |

<sup>285</sup> A 1634 edict fixed the legal allowance of salt measurers at 2 *deniers* per *minot* of salt measured. Voysin's data, reproduced in Appendix Table 9, makes it possible to approximate the emoluments of each salt measurer. For each *grenier*, We take the *quantité vendue*, multiply it by two *deniers* per *minot*, convert to *livres*, then divide by the number of salt measurers posted there. As shown here, the return from emoluments varies from 1–3%, but what is perhaps most interesting is the moderately high *annuel* rates. This is due to the *évaluation*, the office's fiscal base of reference, exceeding the administratively assessed *prix courant*. Usually, the *prix courant* greatly exceeds the *évaluation*, especially for high-value offices. In this case, the low emoluments of measurers and the lack of *taille* privilege caused the value of the office to drop below the *évaluation*, resulting in an inflated *annuel*; BnF 500 Colbert 260, folios 197–200; Voysin, *Mémoire*, 133–134.

**Appendix Table 16. Composition of officers among individuals condemned by the *chambre de justice* of 1661–1665.<sup>286</sup>**

a)

|                                                    |     |
|----------------------------------------------------|-----|
| <b>Number of the condemned</b>                     | 248 |
| <b>Individuals identified</b>                      | 229 |
| <b>Officers</b>                                    | 214 |
| <i>Secrétaires du roi</i>                          | 145 |
| <i>Secrétaires du roi</i> who held no other office | 42  |

b)

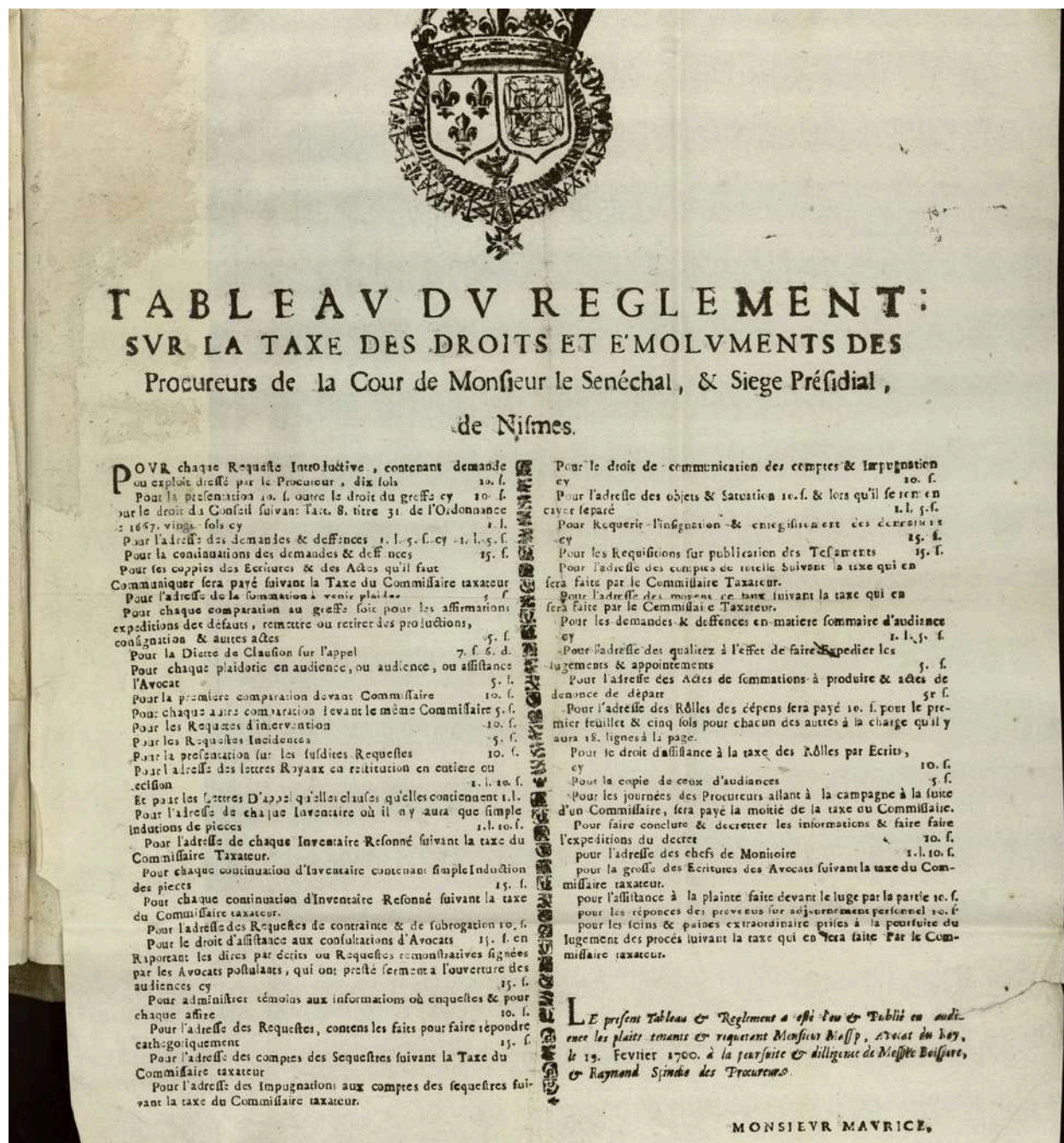
| <b>Office</b>                                    | <b>Number</b> |
|--------------------------------------------------|---------------|
| <i>Receveurs généraux des finances</i>           | 31            |
| <i>Trésoriers de France</i>                      | 11            |
| <i>Contrôleurs (divers)</i>                      | 11            |
| <i>Trésoriers des parties casuelles</i>          | 10            |
| <i>Élus et receveurs des tailles et taillons</i> | 10            |
| <i>Payeurs des rentes</i>                        | 10            |
| <i>Maîtres d'hôtel du roi</i>                    | 10            |
| <i>Secrétaires du conseil des finances</i>       | 9             |
| <i>Trésoriers de l'épargne</i>                   | 7             |
| <i>Commis de l'épargne</i>                       | 7             |
| <i>Trésoriers et contrôleurs des guerres</i>     | 7             |

<sup>286</sup> These tables come from: Dessert, 'Finances', 852.

|                                                   |    |
|---------------------------------------------------|----|
| <i>Trésoriers (divers)</i>                        | 7  |
| <i>Grands audienciers de France</i>               | 7  |
| <i>Intendants des finances</i>                    | 6  |
| <i>Receveurs (divers)</i>                         | 6  |
| <i>Maîtres en la chambre des comptes</i>          | 5  |
| <i>Trésoriers généraux des états</i>              | 5  |
| <i>Greffiers du conseil (+1 commis au greffe)</i> | 4  |
| <i>Trésoriers de la marine</i>                    | 4  |
| <i>Maîtres des requêtes</i>                       | 3  |
| <i>Conseillers au parlement</i>                   | 2  |
| <i>Avocats au conseil</i>                         | 2  |
| <i>Receveurs généraux du clergé</i>               | 2  |
| <i>Maîtres de la chambre aux deniers</i>          | 2  |
| <i>Surintendants généraux des postes</i>          | 2  |
| <i>Secrétaire d'état</i>                          | 1  |
| <i>Commis au greffe</i>                           | 1  |
| <i>Trésorier des ordres du roi</i>                | 1  |
| <i>Grand maître des eaux et forêts</i>            | 1  |
| <i>Offices divers</i>                             | 14 |

## Appendix Figure 1. Structure of fees for the *sénéchaussée* and *présidial* court of Nîmes in 1700.<sup>287</sup>

Currency is denominated in *livres* (l.), *sols* (s.), and *deniers* (d.).



**TABLEAU DV REGLEMENT:  
SVR LA TAXE DES DROITS ET E'MOLVMENTS DES  
Procureurs de la Cour de Monsieur le Senéchal, & Siege Présidial,  
de Nîmes.**

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                                                                     |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>P</b> OUR chaque Requête Introductive, contenant demande ou exploit dressé par le Procureur, dix sols 10. s.                                                                                                              | Pour le droit de communication des comptes & Impugnations 10. s.                                                                                    |
| Pour la présentation 10. s. outre le droit du greffe cy 10. s.                                                                                                                                                               | Pour l'adresse des objets & Satisfaction 10. s. & lors qu'il se rem en                                                                              |
| Pour le droit du Conseil suivant l'art. 8. titre 31. de l'Ordonnance 1667. vingt. sols cy 2. l.                                                                                                                              | cuyer séparé 2. l. 5. s.                                                                                                                            |
| Pour l'adresse des demandes & défenses 1. l. 5. s. cy 1. l. 5. s.                                                                                                                                                            | Pour Requerir l'insinuation & enregistrement des censures 15. s.                                                                                    |
| Pour la continuation des demandes & défenses 15. s.                                                                                                                                                                          | Pour les Requisitions sur publication des Testaments 15. s.                                                                                         |
| Pour les copies des Ecritures & des Actes qu'il faut Communiquer sera payé suivant la Taxe du Commissaire taxateur                                                                                                           | Pour l'adresse des comptes de tutelle suivant la taxe qui en sera faite par le Commissaire Taxateur.                                                |
| Pour l'adresse de la sommation à venir plaider 5. s.                                                                                                                                                                         | Pour l'adresse des moyens de taxe suivant la taxe qui en sera faite par le Commissaire Taxateur.                                                    |
| Pour chaque comparution au greffe soit pour les affirmations, expéditions des défauts, remette ou retirer des productions, consignation & autres actes 5. s.                                                                 | Pour les demandes & défenses en matière sommaire d'audience 1. l. 5. s.                                                                             |
| Pour la Diette de Clause sur l'appel 7. s. 6. d.                                                                                                                                                                             | Pour l'adresse des qualitez à l'effet de faire expédier les                                                                                         |
| Pour chaque plaidoirie en audience, ou audience, ou assistance l'Avocat 5. s.                                                                                                                                                | jugements & appointements 5. s.                                                                                                                     |
| Pour la première comparution devant Commissaire 10. s.                                                                                                                                                                       | Pour l'adresse des Actes de sommations à produire & actes de                                                                                        |
| Pour chaque autre comparution devant le même Commissaire 5. s.                                                                                                                                                               | denonciation de départ 5. s.                                                                                                                        |
| Pour les Requêtes d'intervention 10. s.                                                                                                                                                                                      | Pour l'adresse des Rôles des dépens sera payé 10. s. pour le premier feuillet & cinq sols pour chacun des autres à la charge qu'il y                |
| Pour les Requêtes incidences 5. s.                                                                                                                                                                                           | aura 18. lignes à la page.                                                                                                                          |
| Pour la présentation sur les susdites Requêtes 10. s.                                                                                                                                                                        | Pour le droit d'assistance à la taxe des Rôles par Ecrits, 10. s.                                                                                   |
| Pour l'adresse des lettres Royaux en restitution en entier ou section 2. l. 10. s.                                                                                                                                           | Pour la copie de ceux d'audiences 5. s.                                                                                                             |
| Et pour les Lettres d'appel qu'elles clauses qu'elles contiennent 1. l.                                                                                                                                                      | Pour les journées des Procureurs allant à la campagne à la suite d'un Commissaire, sera payé la moitié de la taxe du Commissaire.                   |
| Pour l'adresse de chaque Inventaire où il n'y aura que simple Induction de pièces 1. l. 10. s.                                                                                                                               | Pour faire conclure & decreter les informations & faire faire l'expédition du decret 10. s.                                                         |
| Pour l'adresse de chaque Inventaire Refonné suivant la taxe du Commissaire Taxateur.                                                                                                                                         | Pour l'adresse des chefs de Monitoire 1. l. 10. s.                                                                                                  |
| Pour chaque continuation d'Inventaire contenant simple Induction des pièces 15. s.                                                                                                                                           | Pour la grosse des Ecritures des Avocats suivant la taxe du Commissaire taxateur.                                                                   |
| Pour chaque continuation d'Inventaire Refonné suivant la taxe du Commissaire taxateur.                                                                                                                                       | Pour l'assistance à la plainte faite devant le juge par la partie 10. s.                                                                            |
| Pour l'adresse des Requêtes de contrainte & de subrogation 10. s.                                                                                                                                                            | Pour les réponses des prévenus sur adjournement personnel 10. s.                                                                                    |
| Pour le droit d'assistance aux consultations d'Avocats 15. s. en Rapportant les dires par écrits ou Requêtes démonstratives signées par les Avocats postulants, qui ont presté serment à l'ouverture des audiences cy 15. s. | Pour les soins & peines extraordinaires prises à la poursuite du Jugement des procès suivant la taxe qui en sera faite par le Commissaire taxateur. |
| Pour administrer témoins aux informations où enquêtes & pour chaque affaire 10. s.                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                     |
| Pour l'adresse des Requêtes, contents les faits pour faire répondre catégoriquement 15. s.                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                     |
| Pour l'adresse des comptes des Sequestres suivant la Taxe du Commissaire taxateur                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                                                                     |
| Pour l'adresse des Impugnations aux comptes des sequestres suivant la taxe du Commissaire taxateur.                                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                     |

**LE présent Tableau & Règlement a esté luy & Tablé en audience les plaignants & requérants Monsieur Bissip, Avocat du Roy, le 19. Fevrier 1700. à la poursuite & diligence de Messie Boissure, & Raymond Spinola des Procureurs.**

MONSIEUR MAVRICE.

<sup>287</sup> Tableau du reglement sur la taxe des droits et émoluments des procureurs de la cour de monsieur le senéchal, & siege présidial, de Nîmes (Nîmes, 1700).

**Appendix Figure 2. Portrait of Omer Talon, *avocat général* in the *Parlement* of Paris, by Philippe de Champaigne.**

Philippe de Champaigne, *Omer Talon*, 1649, oil on canvas, 225 x 161.6 cm (National Gallery of Art, Washington).



**Appendix Figure 3. Portrait of Pierre Monnerot, *receveur général des finances* for the *généralité* of Orléans, by Nicolas de Plattemontagne.**

Nicolas de Plattemontagne, *Pierre Monnerot*, 1656, print, 320 x 253 mm (British Museum, Oxford).



**Appendix Figure 4. Portrait of Jean-Baptiste Colbert, *contrôleur général des finances*, by Philippe de Champaigne.**

Philippe de Champaigne, *Jean-Baptiste Colbert*, 1655, oil on canvas, 92.1 x 72.4 cm (The Met, New York).



Appendix Figure 5. Offices of the *élection* of Caudebec listed in Colbert's *Enquête*.<sup>288</sup>

*L'élection de Caudebec.*

|                             |   |      |   |       |     |       |       |
|-----------------------------|---|------|---|-------|-----|-------|-------|
| Providence                  | 2 | 444  | 1 | 4800  | 80  | 10000 | 20000 |
| Lutetium                    | 1 | 514  | 1 | 4800  | 80  | 8000  | 8000  |
| Premier Escri               | 1 | 444  | 1 | 4000  | 66  | 7000  | 7000  |
| Esclat                      | 4 | 444  | 1 | 4000  | 66  | 6000  | 24000 |
| Procurator du Roy           | 1 | 229  | 1 | 2666  | 44  | 6000  | 6000  |
| Greffier                    | 1 | 378  | 1 |       |     | 10000 | 10000 |
| Receveur Ancien des tailles | 1 | 1848 | 1 | 10000 | 166 | 35000 | 35000 |

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| Noms d'offices                  | Nombre | gages | Quar <sup>tes</sup> | évaluation | Annuel | Prix courant | Total |
|---------------------------------|--------|-------|---------------------|------------|--------|--------------|-------|
| Receveur des tailles alternatif | 1      | 2290  | 1                   | 10000      | 166    | 40000        | 40000 |
| Auxiliet com. des tailles       | 6      |       |                     | 600        | 10     | 2000         | 12000 |
| Amirauté audancieva             | 3      |       |                     | 800        | 13     | 1000         | 3000  |
| Procurator                      | 4      |       |                     |            |        | 400          | 1600  |

<sup>288</sup> From left to right, the columns record the office name, the number of offices, the *gages*, the number of quarterly payments, the 1638 fiscal *évaluation*, the *droit annuel*, the assessed *prix courant*, and the aggregate value; BnF 500 Colbert 260, folios 191–192.